

The Ninth Winter

An Amish Suspense Novel

by Rebecca Miller

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The Ninth Winter

The Lapp baby came at twenty past three in the morning, which was, in Rebecca Yoder's professional opinion, exactly when babies preferred to come.

She had known it would be a long one from the moment she stepped into the house. Not from anything Katie Lapp said, because Katie was on her fourth and had the particular stubborn silence of a woman who had decided in advance not to make a fuss, but from the way the older children had been sent to the grandparents two days early, and from the way Enos Lapp had laid the fire in the front room at nine o'clock and then sat beside it doing nothing at all.

Men who sat doing nothing at all knew something.

"You've time yet," Rebecca had told Katie at midnight, and Katie had said, "I know," in a voice that meant *don't patronize me*, and they had understood each other after that.

Now the lamp threw its yellow circle across the bed and the room smelled of clean linen and lamp oil and the particular animal smell of the work, and Rebecca had her hands where they needed to be, and she said, "Now, Katie. This one."

The baby came into her hands. A girl, small, furious, entirely alive.

There was a moment, and there was always this moment, and in nine years of the work Rebecca had never stopped noticing it, when the room contained a person it had not contained a breath before. Nothing in the *Ordnung*, nothing in any sermon she had sat through on a hard bench in a cold barn, had ever explained that moment to her satisfaction. It simply happened, again and again, in rooms like this one, at hours like this one.

"A girl," she said.

Katie began to cry, which she had not done through eleven hours of labor.

Rebecca did the work that came after: the cord, the cleaning, the weighing on the little brass scale she carried in her bag, the writing down. Seven pounds and two ounces. Born 3:22 a.m., the fourteenth of January. She wrote it in the notebook she kept for the purpose, in her small even hand, and then she wrapped the baby and put her against her mother, and went to tell Enos.

He was still in the chair by the fire. He looked up and she saw that he had been afraid, and that he would never say so, not to her and not to Katie and probably not to God.

"Both well," she said. "A daughter."

Enos Lapp nodded twice. Then he said, "*Denki*," and then, because that was not enough and he knew it, he said it again.

She did not go home.

There was no particular reason to stay. Katie's mother would arrive at six, and there was nothing left that needed a midwife. But the roads were bad and her horse was tired and Katie had asked her, in the loose sleepy voice women got afterward, to stay until light.

So Rebecca sat in the kitchen with a cup of coffee she did not drink and listened to the house.

It was the fourteenth of January.

She was aware of this the way you are aware of a stone in your shoe. Not a thought. A condition.

Nine years ago on the fourteenth of January, her sister Sarah had been alive and asleep in the room across the hall. Nine years ago on the sixteenth, she had not been.

Two days. That was the arithmetic that lived in Rebecca now, that had lived in her every January since she was nineteen years old. She did not choose to do it. It did itself, in the back of her mind, while her hands did other things.

Nine years and two days.

She had never told anyone that she counted. There was no one to tell it to who would have received it well. Her mother had put Sarah away in a place inside herself and closed the door and lived there beside it for nine years. The bishop, if she had gone to him, would have spoken kindly about the danger of holding on to grief past the season God gave for it. Her friends had been seventeen and eighteen at the

time, and were now women with four children and no time, and the person you could have said such a thing to at eighteen was not the same person at twenty-eight.

So she counted alone, and told no one, and it had become as much a part of her as her hands.

Outside, the sky began doing the thing it did in January in Lancaster County, which was not so much getting lighter as getting less absolutely dark.

Katie's mother came at ten past six with a covered dish and the particular energy of a woman arriving at a house where she intended to take over. Rebecca gave her the report, packed her bag, and went out to hitch the horse.

The cold took her breath for a second at the door. Fifteen degrees, maybe less, and the snow from Tuesday still lying hard and gray along the fence line.

She was tightening the last strap when she heard the buggy coming up the Lapps' lane and looked up, expecting Enos's brother.

It was Samuel Fisher, and he had the look of a man carrying news he has enjoyed carrying.

"Rebecca."

"Samuel."

"You'll not have heard." He said it happily. "You've been in there all night."

"I've been working."

"Beiler's back."

Her hands stopped on the strap.

She did not turn around at once. She was aware of that afterward, of the fact that her body had decided, in the space of half a second, that she needed to arrange her face before showing it to Samuel Fisher.

"Which Beiler?" she said, though there was only one.

"*Daniel.*" Samuel leaned forward on the seat, delighted. "Came in on the bus at Gap yesterday evening. Walked to his mother's from the crossroads with a bag. Nine years and he walks up the lane like he'd been to the hardware store." He clicked at his horse. "He's asked to see the bishop. Everybody's saying it. He wants to come back."

The strap was tight. Rebecca checked it again anyway, because it gave her hands something to be doing.

"Well," she said.

"*Well?*" Samuel repeated, disappointed. He had come up the lane for something better than that.

Rebecca climbed into her buggy and picked up the reins and looked at him, and Samuel Fisher, who was thirty-four and had never in his life been able to hold anyone's eye for long, found something interesting on the dashboard.

"It's the fourteenth of January," she said. "Tell me. Did he come back on purpose this week, do you think, or does he not know what week it is?"

Samuel opened his mouth and closed it.

She turned the horse and went down the lane, and the sun came up somewhere behind the gray, and she counted, the way she did, the way she had every day for nine years:

Two days.

What the Community Does With a Man Who Left

Church was at the Stoltzfus place that Sunday, which meant three hours on a backless bench in a barn with the doors open at both ends and every woman in Willow Creek pretending she was not watching the men's side.

Rebecca sat where she always sat, fourth row, between her mother and old Naomi Esh who was deaf in her left ear and therefore sat on Rebecca's right so she could hear the singing.

Daniel Beiler sat at the very back.

Not with the married men, because he was not married. Not with the young men, because he was thirty-two and had been gone nine years and did not belong there either. At the back, alone, on the end of the bench, in a coat that was the right color and the wrong cut, bought or borrowed, made by someone who knew what a Plain coat looked like but not how it was supposed to sit.

The singing started. The *Loblied*, the way it always was, the second hymn, the one that took twenty minutes because you held each syllable until it turned into something that had stopped being a word.

Rebecca sang it and thought about nothing, which was what the *Loblied* was for.

Then in the third verse she heard, underneath the sixty other voices, a man's voice at the back of the barn that had not sung this in nine years and remembered every note of it.

Her own voice went unsteady for a bar and a half. Her mother's head turned a quarter inch.

She got it back.

At the meal afterward, the community did what a community does, which is nothing, very deliberately, in a way that everyone can see.

Nobody refused to speak to Daniel Beiler. That was not the way. The bann had never been laid on him. He had left before baptism, in the year of his *rumspringa*, which meant that technically, doctrinally, in the eyes of the *Ordnung* and of God, he had done nothing that required shunning. He had simply gone out and not come back, and there were young men who did that in every district in Lancaster County, and their mothers wept and their fathers did not speak of it and life continued.

So nobody refused to speak to him. They simply had a great deal to do.

Rebecca watched it from the women's table, over the heads of forty people eating bread and pickles and cold roast beef off borrowed plates. She watched Daniel stand at the edge of the men with his hands at his sides. She watched three separate men greet him, pleasantly, briefly, and then remember something. She watched him accept it without any expression at all, which told her more about the last nine years than anything else could have.

"He's thinner," said Naomi Esh, at a volume calibrated for her own bad ear.

Rebecca said nothing.

"Thinner and older. That's what the world does." Naomi took another pickle. "It puts the years on faster out there. I don't know why."

"He's thirty-two, Naomi. He'd be older here too."

"Not like that," said Naomi, and Rebecca had to admit, silently, that this was probably true.

Her mother did not speak on the drive home.

That was not unusual. Miriam Yoder had never been a talker, and in the nine years since Sarah she had refined not-talking into something closer to an art form. But there was ordinary silence and there was the other kind, and Rebecca had learned to tell them apart the way you learn to tell two greens apart if you spend enough time in a garden.

They were half a mile from home before Miriam said, "You'll not go to him."

Rebecca kept her eyes on the road. "I hadn't planned on it."

"That's not what I asked."

"You didn't ask anything, *Mamm*."

The horse's hooves on the packed snow. The particular creak of the buggy's left side that Rebecca had been meaning to have seen to since November.

"He was the last one with her," Miriam said.

"He was one of four people at that quarry that night, and the other three were girls, and they all told the police the same thing." Rebecca heard her own voice come out flatter than she intended. "He walked back to the crossroads at half nine. Emma Stoltzfus saw him on the road. It's in the report."

"You've read the report."

It was not a question, and Rebecca did not answer it, because the answer was: yes, four times, and the last time was in June, and she had driven to the county building in a hired car with an *Englisch* driver and paid eleven dollars for a copy and read it in the buggy shed with a flashlight like a girl reading something forbidden.

They came up their own lane. Rebecca got down to open the gate.

When she got back up, her mother was looking straight ahead at the house, and she said, in a completely different voice, a small one, an old one, one Rebecca had heard maybe three times in her life:

"I don't want it started again, Rebecca."

"Nothing's started."

"Something always starts," said Miriam Yoder. "That's the trouble with it."

That night Rebecca lay in the dark in the room she had shared with her sister until she was nineteen, in the bed by the window, with the other bed six feet away holding nothing but a folded quilt.

She had asked, once, in the second year, whether they might move the other bed out.

Her mother had said they would see about it in the spring.

That was seven springs ago.

The Box in the Lapps' Attic

Katie Lapp got milk fever on the Thursday, which is how Rebecca came to be in the attic.

The fever itself was not the attic's fault. It was a blocked duct that had gone the wrong way, the way they sometimes did on a fourth baby, and by the time Enos sent the boy for her Katie had a temperature of a hundred and three and the particular glassy look Rebecca did not like at all.

She did what could be done: hot cloths, the right pressure in the right place, water, and a note for the *Englisch* doctor in Gap in case the fever did not break by morning. It broke by four in the afternoon. Katie slept. The baby fed.

And Enos Lapp, who did not know what to do with a woman in his house who had just spent six hours saving his wife from something he had not understood was dangerous, said: "There's things of your sister's in the attic."

Rebecca, washing her hands at the pump, went completely still.

"What?"

"I've been meaning." He was not looking at her. He was looking at the stove. "Nine years I've been meaning. My mother had them. She was the one cleared out the sewing room at your place, after. Your *mamm* couldn't do it and my mother did it, and there was a box she couldn't put on the fire, and she brought it here and put it in the attic, and then she died and I forgot it was there until I was up for the cradle in December."

The pump handle was cold under Rebecca's hand.

"There was a box," she said.

"There was a box."

"Everything was burned. That's what they told me. The clothes went to the neighbors and the rest was burned."

"Aye, well," said Enos Lapp, and rubbed the back of his neck, and there it was: the whole of it, in three words. *Aye, well.* Things get said, and things get done, and they are not always the same things.

The attic was cold enough that her breath showed.

It was a farm attic, which meant it was full: broken chairs kept for parts, a cradle, jars, a headboard, the smell of dust and old wood and mouse. Enos held the lamp because the light was bad and because, Rebecca understood, he did not want her to be up there alone with it.

The box was under the eaves on the north side. A hat box, cardboard, the lid tied down with string.

Rebecca knelt in the dust and put her hands on it and did not open it.

"I'll leave you," Enos said.

"No." Too fast. She heard how fast, and softened it. "No. Stay. I'll — it'll be nothing. It'll be hair ribbons."

It was not hair ribbons.

She untied the string and took the lid off and looked at nine years.

On top: a pressed handkerchief with S.Y. embroidered in the corner in blue, which Rebecca herself had done as a girl and done badly, the Y crooked.

Under it: a birthday card from an *Englisch* girl called Danielle who had worked at the market stand with Sarah in the summer of the year before.

Under that: a hair comb, plain, wooden.

Under that: a recipe notebook, a school exercise book with a soft blue cover, the kind sold at the Gap general store for forty cents.

And under that, wrapped in a square of muslin, a silver hair clip with a scrollwork pattern and three small blue stones.

Rebecca sat back on her heels in the cold and looked at it lying in her palm.

An Amish girl did not own that. Not because she could not (there was no rule, exactly, written anywhere, about hair clips) but because there was no place in the whole architecture of her life where such a thing could be worn, or shown, or explained. It was not *rumspringa* jewelry, the cheap loud stuff the boys bought at the mall and the girls kept in their coat pockets. It was worked silver, old, and it had been wrapped in muslin and put in a box under a pile of ordinary things.

"That's not hers," said Enos Lapp, from the top of the stairs.

"No."

"I've never seen the like."

"No," said Rebecca. "Nor have I."

She put it back in the muslin. She put the muslin in her apron pocket, not the box, and she was aware as she did it that she had just made a decision, and that it was the kind of decision that does not announce itself as one.

Then she picked up the recipe book, and it fell open the way books do at the page you have opened most often.

Shoofly Pie, Mammi's.

Half a cup molasses. Three quarters cup boiling water. And in the margin, in Sarah's round careful hand, in pencil:

11/2, W.G. 40

And below it:

11/9, W.G. 40

And below that, and below that, down the margin and onto the next page, dates and initials and numbers, in a recipe book, in a girl's handwriting, for eleven pages.

Rebecca closed it.

"Rebecca?"

"I'll take these," she said. Her voice came out perfectly level, which surprised her. "The book and the — I'll take the box, Enos. *Denki.* For keeping it."

"I'd have brought it years since. If I'd remembered."

"I know."

She carried the box down the ladder and out through the kitchen where Katie slept with her daughter on her chest, and put it under the seat of the buggy, and drove home in the last of the light with a dead girl's arithmetic under the boards at her feet.

Eleven Pages of Arithmetic

She did not look at the notebook that night.

She told herself it was because there was no lamp to spare and no room in the house where she could sit with it unobserved. Both true, and both beside the point. The truth was simpler and she knew it while she was thinking the other things: she was afraid of what was in it, and being afraid of a school exercise book with a soft blue cover was so absurd that she could not say it to herself in plain words.

She put the box under her bed. She slept badly.

In the morning she took the buggy out at half past six, told her mother she was going to look in on Katie Lapp, and drove instead to the far end of the Millers' back lane, where there was a stand of hemlock and no house within half a mile, and sat in the buggy with a blanket over her knees and the notebook open on top of it.

Eleven pages.

The first four were recipes. Actual recipes, in Sarah's hand: shoofly pie, chow-chow, a chicken pot pie with a note that said *Mamm uses more salt, too much*. Rebecca read them with her thumb pressed hard against the edge of the page, because her sister's handwriting was doing something to her that she had not been prepared for and that she needed to get past in order to be useful.

Then, from the margin of the shoofly page onward:

11/2,	W.G.	40
11/9,	W.G.	40
11/16,	W.G.	40
11/23, W.G.	60	

Down the margin, then filling the blank half of the page, then two full pages of nothing else.

Rebecca went back to the first entry and started to work.

The dates were dates: the second of November, the ninth, the sixteenth. Weekly, always the same day. She checked it against the almanac in her head and got Thursdays, all of them Thursdays.

The initials were the difficulty. W.G. appeared in every entry from November through the following August, when the notebook stopped. But then there were others, in a second column that started in the spring:

4/6,	W.G.	40,	E.M.	25
4/13,	W.G.	40,	E.M.	25
4/20, W.G. 40, E.M. 20, J.R. 15				

By July there were five sets of initials in the second column and the numbers had grown small and cramped to fit.

The numbers were money. She was sure of that before she could have said why. Something in the way they sat, in the roundness of them, forty and forty and sixty, the way a wage sits.

What she could not make come out right was the arithmetic. If W.G. was paying forty, and E.M. was receiving twenty-five, then twenty-five and forty did not balance, and Sarah had been a girl who could add.

Unless.

Rebecca sat back against the buggy seat and looked at the hemlocks with the notebook open on her knees and let the thought arrive at its own speed, because it was not a thought she wanted to hurry.

Unless the first number was what was *paid* and the second was what was *received*, and Sarah had been writing down the difference.

11/2,	W.G.	40.	Forty	dollars	leaves	someone's	hand.
4/6, W.G. 40, E.M. 25. Forty leaves. Twenty-five arrives.							

Fifteen dollars a week, from one man, for one week. And by July, five names.

Rebecca did the sum in her head, the way she did the weights of babies, and got a figure that made her put the notebook down on the seat beside her and press both hands flat against her eyes.

She stayed there over an hour. When she came back to herself the horse had eaten everything within reach of the traces and the cold had got into her feet.

She made herself go through it once more, slowly, looking for the way she might be wrong. This was a habit of her work: when a thing looked bad, you checked whether you were the one making it look bad.

It could be a store account. Someone owing, someone paying. But then why the second column, and why five names by summer, and why in a recipe book hidden in the middle of pie crust?

It could be a game. Girls kept ledgers of foolish things. She had herself, at fifteen, kept a list of every boy at every singing and what they had said to her, and burned it at seventeen out of pure shame.

But a girl's foolish ledger did not run nine months and it did not have initials that repeated and it did not stop, abruptly, in the third week of August, with half a page left blank.

The last entry was:

8/17, W.G. 40, E.M. 25, J.R. 15, R.T. 20, L.C. 15

And then, underneath, not in the columns, in the ordinary way one writes a sentence:

Ask him what he tells them it is for.

Sarah Yoder had drowned on the sixteenth of January, five months after that line was written.

There was a thing Rebecca had believed for nine years, which she had never examined because it had never needed examining, and which she felt shift under her now like ice going.

The thing she had believed was: *nothing happened.*

Not *someone did something and got away with it.* Not *there is a story here.* Simply: her sister had gone to the quarry on a January night with three friends and a boy, had gone down to the water alone at some point in the evening, and had gone through where the ice was thin, and had died the way people do die, stupidly, for no reason, in a way that gets called an accident because there is no better word for it.

Nine years of counting had been the counting of a thing without a cause. That was its own particular kind of grief and Rebecca had learned to live inside it.

She sat in the hemlocks with the notebook on her knees and understood that she might have been living inside the wrong grief entirely, and that the right one, if it turned out to be the right one, was going to be considerably worse.

Then she wrapped the notebook in the muslin with the silver clip, and put both under the seat, and drove home to lie to her mother about Katie Lapp.

Put It Back Where It Was

She managed four days.

Four days of carrying it: in her apron in the morning, under the mattress at night, once, ridiculously, in the bottom of her midwife's bag on a call to the Hostetlers, because she could not stand the thought of it being in the house without her.

Four days of watching her mother move around the kitchen and thinking: *you might know something.*

On the fifth day it came out of her at the worst possible moment, which is how these things generally happen.

They were doing the wash. It was a Monday, and in January the wash meant the wringer on the porch and the lines strung in the cellar because nothing would dry outside, and it was a long cold job that put them side by side for three hours with their hands busy.

Miriam said, "The Fisher girl's expecting."

"I know."

"You'd not said."

"I don't tell you everything I know about who's expecting, *Mamm*. It's half my work."

"You told me about Katie Lapp."

"Katie Lapp had milk fever and I was gone all night."

The wringer squealed. Steam came off the tub and hung in the cold air of the porch.

Rebecca said, "I found Sarah's things."

She had not decided to say it. She heard it as her mother heard it.

Miriam Yoder's hands went on working the wringer for one turn, two turns, three. Then they stopped.

"What things."

"A box. In the Lapps' attic. Enos's mother took it when she cleared the sewing room — she couldn't put it on the fire, so she kept it, and then she died and it stayed there." Rebecca's own hands had stopped too. "There's a handkerchief. The one I embroidered wrong. A card from that *Englisch* girl at the market. A comb."

"And?"

Rebecca looked at her mother's profile and made the choice.

"And her recipe book."

Something happened in Miriam's face. It was not surprise. That was the thing Rebecca would come back to over the following weeks, turning it over: whatever her mother's face did in that moment, it was not the thing a face does when it is hearing something for the first time.

"Put it back where it was," Miriam said.

"Back in the Lapps' attic?"

"Back in the box. Under the bed, wherever you've got it. Put it back and leave it."

"*Mamm.*"

"You'll have your dinner cold if we're not done by twelve." Miriam started the wringer again. "Pass me those."

Rebecca did not pass her those.

"There's writing in it," she said. "In the margins. Dates and letters and numbers, nine months of them, and they're not recipes."

The wringer stopped a second time.

"I've done the sums," Rebecca said. "Somebody was paying out forty dollars and somebody else was getting twenty-five, and the difference was going somewhere, and by the summer there were five names in it. And on the last page she wrote — "

"Rebecca."

" — she wrote *ask him what he tells them it is for*, and five months later she was dead, and nobody has ever once — "

"*Rebecca.*"

Her mother had turned around.

Miriam Yoder was fifty-four years old and had a face that had been made by weather and work and one particular January, and Rebecca had spent nine years reading it and had never in that time seen what was on it now.

Her mother was afraid.

Not grieving. Not angry, though the anger would come and would be easier for both of them. Afraid, the way you are afraid of a thing you have already met once and hoped not to meet again.

"Do you know what they did," Miriam said, "when your sister died?"

"They buried her."

"Before that. The week after." Her voice had gone very quiet. "The whole church came. Every family. There was food in this house for eleven days and I did not cook one meal of it. Men I'd not spoken to in a year came and did the milking. Sadie Beiler washed the floors of a house that wasn't hers, on her knees, for a week."

"I remember. I was there."

"You were nineteen and you were somewhere else, in your head, and I don't blame you for it." Miriam's hands were wringing the corner of her apron, not the wash. "That is what they gave us. And what they asked, in return, without ever once asking it out loud, was that we not tear the district apart looking for somebody to blame for the ice on a quarry pond."

"And if it wasn't the ice?"

"Then it is nine years past and there is nothing to be done about it that is worth what it would cost."

The word sat there on the cold porch between them.

Cost.

"That's not a no," Rebecca said slowly. "*Mamm*, listen to yourself. That's not *nothing happened.* That's *it would cost too much.*"

Her mother turned back to the tub.

"Get the other basket," she said. "It'll be dark by four."

They finished the wash. They ate dinner. Miriam said nothing else about it, that day or the next, and by Wednesday the whole conversation had been folded up and put away in the manner of the household, and Rebecca knew that if she raised it again she would be raising it against a locked door.

But she did not put the notebook back in the box.

She took the muslin bundle out to the buggy shed on Tuesday night with a candle, and pried up the loose board under the workbench where she had hidden things as a girl (a novel, once, and a lipstick that Sarah had dared her to buy and that neither of them had ever had the courage to wear) and she put her sister's arithmetic underneath it, and stood the board back, and swept the sawdust over the join with her foot.

At the Fence

He was mending the fence along the Beiler south pasture, which did not need mending, in the third week of January, which is not when you mend fences.

Rebecca understood the arrangement as soon as she saw him: a man who has come home and been given nothing to do, being allowed by his mother to do something visible near the road so that the district could see him working. It was a kindness. It was also a kind of exhibition, and both things were true at once, and that was very much how Willow Creek did its business.

She could have driven past.

She had, twice already that week.

She pulled up.

Daniel Beiler straightened with the wire pliers still in his hand and looked at her across ten feet of frozen ground, and neither of them said anything for what felt to Rebecca like a considerable time.

He had been a rangy boy with a laugh that got him into trouble at singings. He was not rangy now. He had filled out through the shoulders in the way men do who have spent nine years lifting things, and there was a white line through his left eyebrow that had not been there before, and his hands, when she looked at them, were a carpenter's hands with two fingernails gone black.

"Rebecca," he said.

"Daniel."

"I heard you'd taken your mother's work."

"You heard right."

"She was good at it. Your mother." He set the pliers on the post. "She birthed my sister's first."

"She's not done it in nine years."

He absorbed that. She watched him absorb it and understood that he had not known, and that a great many things about the last nine years in this district had not reached him, and that he was going to be finding them out one at a time for months.

"I'm sorry," he said.

"For what?"

And Daniel Beiler, who had always been quicker than was good for him, said: "You'll have to tell me which part you're asking about, because there's a list."

Rebecca got down from the buggy.

She had not planned to. But standing above a man while you say the thing you have come to say is a coward's position, and if she was going to do this she was going to do it on the same ground.

"Were you there," she said.

He did not pretend not to understand.

"At the quarry. Yes."

"The report says you walked back to the crossroads at half nine."

"I did."

"Emma Stoltzfus saw you on the road."

"She did." He was very still. "You've read it."

"I've read it four times."

Daniel looked away, out over the pasture, and there was a long moment where the only sound was a crow somewhere in the Millers' woodlot.

"Then you'll know," he said, "that it also says I couldn't account for the twenty minutes before that."

"It says you were 'unable to specify' where you were between nine ten and nine thirty."

"That's a nice way to put it. The trooper's way was different." He picked up the pliers again, looked at them, put them down. "I've had nine years to think of a better answer than the one I gave, and I'll tell you what I've come up with, which is nothing. I don't have a better answer. I have the same answer."

"Which is?"

"I was walking," Daniel said. "Round the north side, by myself, in the dark, being seventeen and furious about something that I could not tell you now if you paid me."

That's it. That's the whole twenty minutes. I walked around a quarry in a temper and by the time I came back the girls had gone up to the fire and I went home."

"And Sarah?"

"Sarah was at the fire when I left the fire," he said. "And Sarah was not at the fire when I got back, and I did not look for her, because I was seventeen and I assumed she'd gone up with Emma, and I walked to the crossroads and Emma passed me in her father's buggy and said good night, and I went home and went to bed."

He said the last part in a completely flat voice, and Rebecca recognized it, because it was the voice she used for the fourteenth of January.

A sentence said so many times that it has stopped having a shape.

"They didn't believe you," she said.

"Some did. The bishop did." Daniel's jaw moved. "My father didn't. That was the one that mattered, and he died in the fourth year, and we hadn't got past it."

The crow again. The cold coming up through her boots.

"Why'd you come back?" Rebecca asked.

"To be forgiven."

"For what, if you didn't do anything?"

And Daniel Beiler looked at her with an expression she could not read at all and said:

"For not looking for her."

She drove home the long way, past the turn to the quarry road, and did not take it.

Here was the difficulty, and she laid it out for herself plainly, because self-deceit was a luxury she had never been able to afford.

One: everything he had said matched the report, in every particular, including the parts that made him look worse. A man who had spent nine years building a story would have built a better one.

Two: she had wanted to believe him from the moment he said her name at the fence, and that was exactly the sort of wanting that made a person stupid.

Three: Sarah had written *W.G.* forty-one times in a recipe book, and Daniel Beiler's initials were D.B.

It was the third one that stayed with her, all the way home, and that she turned over in bed that night.

Because in nine years of thinking about the quarry, Rebecca had been thinking about the wrong question. She had been asking *did somebody do it*, which was a question with a very short list of suspects and no evidence at all.

She had never once asked *what was she doing*.

The Last Ordinary Evening

The thing nobody tells you about the last ordinary evening is that it is ordinary.

There is no weight in it. Nothing hums. The light through the kitchen window on the fifteenth of January, the year Rebecca was nineteen, was exactly the light of the fourteenth and the thirteenth, and the supper was ham and fried potatoes and creamed corn from the jar, and their father was still alive then and read the *Budget* at the table which their mother did not like.

Rebecca had gone over that evening so many times that she no longer entirely trusted it. Memory is a thing you handle, and handling wears it. She was aware that certain details had probably arrived later: that she might have installed them, over the years, out of a need for the evening to mean something.

But some of it was solid, and she went back to the solid parts.

Sarah had been quiet at supper.

That was solid. Sarah at seventeen was not a quiet girl; she was a girl who talked through meals until their father put down the paper and looked at her, which she took as encouragement. That night she had eaten and said almost nothing, and their mother had asked twice if she was sickening for something.

After supper they had done the dishes together, which was solid, because they always did.

And Sarah had said, and Rebecca was certain of this because of what came after: "Do you think *Mamm* ever wanted to be something else?"

Rebecca, nineteen, with a dish in her hand, had said, "Something else than what?"

"Than this."

"Than what *this*, Sarah?"

And Sarah had made a gesture with the towel that took in the kitchen and the window and the lane and the whole of Willow Creek, and said: "Never mind."

Never mind.

Rebecca had let it go. That was the part she could not get past, in nine years. Not the quarry, not the ice, not the trooper in the front room with his hat on his knee. That. A dish in her hand and a chance to say *no, tell me*, and instead: nothing. She had let it go because she had been nineteen and thinking about Amos Kauffman's brother, who had looked at her twice at the last singing, and because her sister's moods were weather and this was just another one.

They had finished the dishes. Sarah had gone up. That was all.

The next evening, the sixteenth, Sarah had said she was going out to the Stoltzfus place with Emma, which was true as far as it went, and at some point in the evening the four of them and Daniel Beiler had gone on to the quarry, which was not unusual and not permitted and not, in the ordinary run of things, dangerous.

Now, sitting on the edge of her bed nine years later with the candle guttering, Rebecca made herself do the thing she had been circling for a week.

She made herself ask what her sister had been like that autumn, and not what she had been like *that night*.

And the answer came up so fast, and so completely, that she understood she had been carrying it the whole time without looking at it.

Sarah had been at the market stand.

Every Thursday from June, and then through the autumn, and then (their mother had complained about it) into the winter, when the stand did half its trade and did not need two girls. She had gone with the Zook family in their wagon, out to the stand on Route 340 where the tour buses came, and sold jam and quilts and shoofly pie to *Engischers* who took photographs of the horses.

Every Thursday.

11/2. 11/9. 11/16. 11/23.

All Thursdays.

Rebecca went very still on the edge of the bed.

The market stand on 340 was four hundred yards from the entrance to the Graber quarry, on the same road. She had driven past both of them perhaps a

thousand times in her life and had never once had reason to put them in the same sentence.

She thought: *W.G.*

She thought: *Wilmer Graber.*

And then she thought, with a coldness that started at the back of her neck and went all the way down: the quarry where the ice was thin was not the Graber quarry. It was the old one, the flooded one, two miles the other way, on the Hostetler side.

Two entirely different places. Two miles apart. A girl who worked four hundred yards from one and drowned in the other.

Rebecca sat with that for a long time.

It proved nothing. It was not even a coincidence, exactly, in a county where everything was four hundred yards from something else.

But it was a shape, and she had spent nine years with no shape at all.

In the morning she did two things.

The first was to go to the buggy shed before dawn, lift the board, and copy the eleven pages of the notebook into her own work ledger: dates, initials, numbers, in her own hand, in the pages after the Lapp baby's weight. It took an hour and forty minutes and her fingers went numb twice.

She did it because of a thought that had come to her at three in the morning and had kept her awake after: *the notebook can be taken.*

The second thing she did was harness the horse and drive out to Route 340, in the cold, and pull up on the shoulder opposite the entrance to Graber Aggregate & Stone, and sit there with the reins in her hands for eleven minutes, looking at the gate.

There was a truck idling in the yard. There were two men by the scale house with their breath showing. There was a sign that said HIRING, INQUIRE WITHIN in English, and underneath it, smaller, a second line in Spanish.

Rebecca read the second line twice.

Then she turned the horse and went home and said nothing about any of it to anyone.

What the Bishop Already Knew

The summons came on a Friday, in the way such things came: not a summons at all, but Ammon Stoltzfus stopping by the gate on his way to the mill to say that his father would be glad if Rebecca could stop in when she was passing.

She was passing that afternoon. Everyone was always passing.

Bishop Amos Stoltzfus was sixty-one and had been bishop for nineteen years, since the lot had fallen to him at forty-two in a room full of men who had all been hoping it would fall to somebody else. Rebecca had known him her whole life. He had baptized her at twenty. He had buried her sister and, four years later, her father.

He was in the shop behind the house when she came, oiling a harness by the window where the light was, and he did not stop when she came in. That was his way. He conducted the serious business of the district while doing something with his hands.

"Rebecca. Sit, if you like."

She sat on the bench by the door.

"The Lapp baby's well?"

"Both well."

"Good. Good." He worked the oil into the leather with his thumb. "It was a hard night, they say."

"Eleven hours. Katie did the work; I only kept her company."

"That's not what Enos says." A brief smile, gone. "Enos says you saved his wife on the Thursday."

"Enos was frightened and I wasn't. That's all a person is paying for, most of the time."

The bishop laughed at that (a real one, short) and Rebecca allowed herself, for a moment, to think that this was going to be an ordinary visit.

Then Amos Stoltzfus said, "You've your sister's box."

The shop was very quiet. Outside, somewhere, one of the grandchildren was calling to another.

"I do," Rebecca said.

"That's a hard thing to come by after so long. I'm sorry it came the way it did — out of an attic, with no warning. That's not how a person should get such a thing."

"No."

"Enos should have brought it to your mother years since."

"He says he forgot it was there."

"He may have done." The bishop turned the harness over. "Or he may have known that bringing it would have made him the man who brought it. People forget a great deal that's inconvenient to remember. It's not always a lie."

Rebecca said nothing.

She was doing arithmetic of a different kind now, and it was going badly.

Enos Lapp had given her the box on Thursday of the week before. She had told her mother on the Monday. She had told nobody else. Not Katie, who had been asleep. Not Daniel. Not a soul.

Eight days. And the bishop of Willow Creek knew about it, and knew it had come out of the Lapps' attic, in a district where a woman could not buy a bonnet in Gap without three people mentioning it. Except that Rebecca had not bought a bonnet, she had carried a cardboard box down a ladder in an empty house with one man watching.

Enos told him.

That was the simple answer and it was probably the right one. Enos Lapp, uneasy about a thing he had done on impulse, going to his bishop the way a man does.

But it was not the only answer, and she found she could not stop the other one arriving: *or somebody has been watching to see whether that box would ever turn up.*

"Rebecca."

She looked up. Amos Stoltzfus had put the harness down.

"There will be things in it," he said, "that will want explaining. That's the nature of what a young person leaves behind. She was seventeen. At seventeen a person is half a dozen people at once and not one of them is finished."

"There's a hair clip," Rebecca said. "Silver. With blue stones."

She had not intended to say that either. She was beginning to distrust her own mouth.

The bishop's face did not change, and she watched it not change with an attention that felt almost violent.

"Then that's a thing to ask your mother about," he said. "Not me."

"And a recipe book."

"Was she a good cook? I forget."

"She was a terrible cook," said Rebecca. "She wrote the recipes down because she couldn't hold them in her head."

"Well." He picked up the harness again. "Then you've got something of her, which is more than you had a month ago, and I'm glad of it for you. Truly."

He said it kindly. Rebecca believed the kindness. That was the trouble with Amos Stoltzfus, and always had been. The kindness was never false.

"Now," he said. "The other thing."

"There's another thing."

"Daniel Beiler has asked to come back."

The change of subject was so smooth that it took Rebecca a moment to feel the join.

"So I hear."

"He'll want instruction and baptism. He was never under the bann, so there's no shunning to lift — but a man who's been nine years in the world doesn't come back the way he left, and the district will need to see him be patient." The bishop looked at her directly for the first time since she had come in. "There are people who will find it hard. Your mother, I should think. And you."

"I'm not the one who has to forgive him. He didn't do anything to me."

"Didn't he?"

Rebecca found she had no answer ready.

"I'll ask you a thing," said the bishop, "and you needn't answer it now. If it turned out that Daniel Beiler had nothing at all to do with your sister — nothing, not a thing, not even carelessness — would that be good news to you, or bad?"

"Good," said Rebecca. "Obviously."

"Mm," said Amos Stoltzfus, and went back to his harness. "Think on it anyway. It's not always obvious. When a person has spent nine years with a thing to hold, it can be a hard business to have it taken out of their hands and be given nothing back in its place."

She was at the door when he spoke again, and he said it lightly, without looking up, in the voice of a man remembering a small errand.

"Rebecca. That box. Bring it to me when you've done with it, would you? It's not right that such things should sit about in a shed."

Rebecca stood with her hand on the door frame.

She had not told him where she had put it.

The Sawdust on the Join

She did not run to the shed.

That was the first thing, and she was proud of it later in a small hard way: she walked out of the bishop's shop, said something appropriate to Ammon's wife at the gate, untied the horse, drove home at the ordinary pace of a woman with nothing pressing, put the horse away, carried her bag into the house, hung her coat, and answered her mother's question about whether the bishop had wanted anything in particular.

"He asked after Katie Lapp," she said.

"That's all?"

"He asked whether I'd find it hard, about Daniel."

Miriam Yoder made a sound that could have meant a number of things and went back to the beans.

Rebecca ate her supper. She washed the dishes. She read a chapter of the *Martyrs Mirror* aloud because it was Friday and that was what they did on Friday, and her mother sat with her mending in her lap and her eyes shut, and at half past eight she took the lamp and went up.

At twenty past ten she came down again in her stockings with a candle she did not light until she was out the kitchen door.

The buggy shed in January at that hour was a place with its own weather. Colder than outside, somehow, the way sheds are, the cold coming up out of the packed dirt floor as much as in through the boards.

She set the candle on the workbench and knelt.

The board was where she had left it.

She had known it would be. She had told herself that on the whole drive home, three separate times, in the reasonable voice she used with frightened first-time mothers, and it had not helped in the least.

But it was more than that, and she made herself look properly before she touched anything.

The sawdust was on the join.

She had swept it there herself with the side of her boot eleven days ago, a thin gray scatter across the seam where the board met the frame, and it lay now exactly as sawdust lies when nothing has disturbed it: unbroken, settled, dulled by the damp. Not a scuff. Not the small clean line a board makes when it is lifted and put back by somebody being careful.

Nobody had been in here.

Rebecca sat back on her heels with her hands on her knees and let that arrange itself.

It's not right that such things should sit about in a shed.

He had said *a shed*. Not *your shed*, not *the buggy shed*, not *under the bench*. A shed. It was the sort of thing a man said. It was very nearly the sort of thing a man said by accident, the way you might say *don't leave it lying about in a drawer somewhere* to a person who had never mentioned a drawer.

She turned it over, looking for the innocent shape of it, because she had spent her working life learning that the frightening explanation is usually not the true one. A breech presentation is usually a baby lying awkwardly, not a disaster. A fever on the fourth day is usually a duct. You check the ordinary thing first, and you check it honestly, or you will spend your life terrifying women for nothing.

So: the ordinary thing.

Enos Lapp had told the bishop about the box. That was almost certainly true and cost nothing to believe. And a man telling his bishop about a box he had kept in his attic for nine years would say, in the telling, *I gave it to Rebecca Yoder and she took it away in her buggy*, and a bishop hearing that would picture a woman driving home with a cardboard box, and would say, later, without thinking about it at all, *don't leave it in a shed*.

That was the ordinary thing. It fit. It required nobody to have done anything.

Rebecca lifted the board.

The muslin bundle was there, exactly as she had left it, the notebook and the silver clip together. She unwrapped it far enough to see the soft blue cover and the corner of the clip, and then she wrapped it again, and she did not put it back.

Because there was a second ordinary thing, and it had been standing behind the first one the whole time, waiting.

Her mother knew about the loose board.

Of course she did. Miriam Yoder had raised two daughters in this house. She had found the novel when Rebecca was fifteen and had put it back without a word, and Rebecca had known she had found it because it was three inches to the left of where it had been, and neither of them had ever spoken of it in thirteen years. That was how her mother did things. She had known about the board since before Sarah could reach it.

Rebecca knelt in the cold with her sister's arithmetic in her hands and thought: *my mother is afraid, and my mother knows where I put things, and my mother has been to the bishop's house twice this month.*

Then she thought, quite deliberately, the way you press on a place that hurts to find out what kind of hurt it is: *and if she did tell him, what would she have been doing?*

And the answer came back immediately and made everything worse, because the answer was: *protecting me.*

She did not sleep much. Toward four she gave up and lit the lamp and sat with her work ledger open on her knees, and read her own careful copy of eleven pages, and made herself do something useful instead of frightened.

The second column. That was the part she had not worked properly.

E.M. 25. J.R. 15. R.T. 20. L.C. 15.

Four sets of initials that appeared in the spring and grew to five by July, each with a number smaller than forty. If the reading was right (forty paid, twenty-five received) then E.M. was a man being handed twenty-five dollars out of forty.

But the others were not twenty-five. They were fifteen, and twenty, and fifteen.

She had assumed, the first time, that this was simply different men on different rates. Now, at four in the morning with her feet cold and her mind unpleasantly clear, she saw the other reading, and it was worse and it was tidier.

The amounts were going down.

Not per man. Per week. *E.M.* had been getting twenty-five in April. By the middle of June, in an entry she had skimmed past three times, there was *E.M. 20*. In August: *E.M. 15*.

Someone had been taking more as the summer went on. Taking more, from more men, and nothing had happened, and so he had taken more again.

Rebecca put her pencil down.

That was not a scheme. A scheme is a thing a man decides on. That was a man finding out, one week at a time, exactly how much he could take before somebody stopped him, and discovering, one week at a time, that nobody was going to.

And a seventeen-year-old girl selling shoofly pie four hundred yards away had written it down for nine months.

Ask him what he tells them it is for.

She had not asked *him*, Rebecca thought. Whatever else Sarah had done, she had not asked Wilmer Graber. Because that line was written on the seventeenth of August, and if she had asked him in August she would not have been alive in January. No. That was not right either. That was the kind of thinking that ran ahead of its evidence.

She might have asked him. That was all that could be said. She had written down the intention to ask, in the last entry, and then the notebook stopped.

Rebecca looked at the blank half page under the final line for a long time.

Nine months of entries, every Thursday without fail, and then nothing. Not a tapering off. Not a few scattered weeks. A girl who had written *11/2, 11/9, 11/16, 11/23* in a hand as regular as a heartbeat had stopped on the seventeenth of August and never written another line, and had gone on living in this house for five more months, and had said nothing to anyone.

Something had happened in the third week of August.

At six she put on her coat, went out while the sky was still black, and did the thing she had decided on somewhere around five.

She did not move the notebook to a better hiding place. There was no better hiding place; that was the trouble with a house and a shed and a district where every building had been put up by the same forty men.

She took the muslin bundle into the house, into the room she had shared with her sister, and she put it in the bed.

Not under it. In it. Under the quilt of the other bed, the one that had held nothing but a folded quilt for nine years, flat against the mattress where the shape of it disappeared entirely.

Her mother had not touched that bed since the spring of the second year. Nobody in the house had. It was the one place in Willow Creek that Rebecca could be perfectly certain no hand would go, because putting a hand there would mean admitting the bed was still there.

She smoothed the quilt down and stood looking at it in the gray light.

"There," she said, out loud, to nobody, in the voice she used for the fourteenth of January.

Then she went down and made the coffee, and at seven her mother came into the kitchen and said good morning, and Rebecca said good morning back, and neither of them said anything else at all.

Graber Aggregate & Stone

The excuse arrived on its own, which Rebecca chose to take as neither providence nor its opposite.

Lydia Zook was seven months along with her third and had begun, in the last fortnight, to swell in the ankles in a way Rebecca did not care for. The Zooks lived on the Gap side of Route 340. Their lane came out two hundred yards east of the market stand.

That was the whole of it. A woman with swollen ankles, a midwife who visited weekly, a road that went past a gate.

She told herself this three times on the drive out and did not believe herself once.

Lydia's ankles were better. Her blood pressure was where it should be. She wanted to talk about her sister-in-law, who was expecting in July and had opinions, and Rebecca let her, and drank the coffee, and stayed forty minutes because a visit of twenty would have been noticed.

Then she came out into the cold and stood by the horse for a moment with her hand on his neck.

The gate was two hundred yards west. She could see the top of the scale house over the hedge.

You have no business there. You have nothing to ask him. You have no way to ask it that does not tell him you are asking.

All true.

She got up into the buggy and turned the horse west.

Graber Aggregate & Stone was not a large operation. Rebecca was not sure what she had expected. Something with a shape to it. What was there was a yard of gray stone dust with a scale house, a portable office on blocks, two sheds, a stack of concrete pipe, three trucks, and beyond it all the cut face of the hill going up gray and wet-looking with snow in the ledges.

There was a bell on a post by the office with a hand-lettered sign: DELIVERIES RING.

She did not ring it. She sat in the buggy just inside the gate with the reins loose in her hands, and within about ninety seconds a man came out of the portable office and down the two wooden steps and across the yard toward her, and she had time to think, with a lurch: *I have not decided what I am doing.*

"Morning," he said.

Wilmer Graber was fifty-something. Heavy through the middle, a canvas coat, a knit cap, reading glasses pushed up on the cap and forgotten there. He had a good open face. That was the first thing Rebecca noticed and the thing she came back to for a long time afterward: he had the face of a man you would ask for directions.

"Good morning," she said.

"You lost, or you want stone?"

"Neither, I'm afraid." She heard her own voice come out easy and was distantly astonished by it. "I'm the midwife. Rebecca Yoder. I've been at the Zooks' and I've a question that isn't any of my business, and I thought I'd ask it badly rather than not at all."

Wilmer Graber laughed. It was a real laugh.

"Well, that's a fine start. Go on."

"Your men. The ones you take on in the season." She nodded at the sign by the gate, at the second line under the English. "Do any of them have wives here? With them, I mean. Living local."

He looked at her for a moment with his head slightly on one side.

"Some do. Two or three families over toward Kinzers. Why?"

"Because if there's a woman expecting within five miles of me I'd rather know about it in the sixth month than in the ninth," said Rebecca. "It's not charity. It's that I don't like being called out to somebody I've never met at two in the morning with no idea what I'm walking into. It happened to me in the second year and I've not forgotten it."

That was true. All of it was true. She had prepared none of it, and every word was true, and she understood as she said it that this was why it was working.

"Huh," said Wilmer Graber. He rubbed the side of his jaw. "I'd not have thought of that."

"No reason you should."

"There's Efrain's boy's wife. She'd be — " He turned and shouted across the yard, in Spanish, three or four words, toward a man stacking pipe. The man shouted back a sentence Rebecca did not understand and held up two fingers. "Two months, he says. Not yours yet. But there's a cousin comes in April and I couldn't tell you a thing about her."

"April's soon enough. If you'd mention my name, that's all I'd ask."

"I'll do that."

He said it easily and she believed he meant it, and that was the worst part of the whole encounter, and it went on being the worst part for weeks.

She should have gone. She knew she should have gone. She had what she had come for, which was nothing, and she had it cleanly, and the horse was standing.

"You've been here a long while," she said.

"Twenty-six years. My father before that, but it was just the one pit then." He turned and looked at the hill with a kind of proprietary irritation. "It was a better business twenty years ago, I'll tell you that."

"My sister worked at the market stand. Down the road."

She had not planned to say it.

Wilmer Graber said, "Which one's that, the Zooks' stand?"

"Yes."

"Half my summer lunches come out of that stand." He smiled. "Which sister?"

And Rebecca Yoder, sitting in her buggy in a stone yard on a gray morning in January, watched a man's face for the truth and found that she could not read a single thing on it.

"Sarah," she said. "Sarah Yoder. She'd have been there nine, ten years back."

"Sarah." He said it the way a man says a name he is being handed. He thought about it, or appeared to. "I couldn't tell you. There's a girl there most summers. My wife'd know — she buys the chow-chow."

"She died," Rebecca said. "Nine years ago this month. At the old quarry, on the Hostetler side."

The change in his face was immediate and, as far as she could tell, entirely genuine.

"*Ach*, now." He took the knit cap off, which she had not expected, and held it. "The girl that went through the ice."

"That's the one."

"I'm sorry. I remember it — everybody remembers it. That was a bad winter altogether." He turned the cap over in his hands. "You'd be — I'm sorry, I've forgotten your name already."

"Rebecca."

"Rebecca. I'm sorry for it. Truly. I've a daughter myself, out in Ohio." He put the cap back on. "They ought to have fenced that place off years before they did. There's a fence on it now, for all the good it does anybody."

"There is," said Rebecca. "They put it up the following spring."

"Aye. Well." Wilmer Graber shook his head slowly. "That's how it goes, isn't it. Nothing gets done till it's too late to do any good, and then it gets done in a hurry so everybody can say something was done."

She sat with that.

It was, she thought afterward, one of the truest things anybody said to her in the whole of that winter, and it had been said by that man, standing in that yard, with his cap in his hands, and meaning it.

"I'll let you get on," she said.

"Mind how you go. That road's ice under the trees past the bend."

"I know it."

"Everybody knows it," said Wilmer Graber, "and every winter somebody goes in the ditch there anyway."

She did not remember the first mile of the drive home.

When she came back to herself she was past the bend, on the ice under the trees, going at a walk with her hands too tight on the reins, and she made herself loosen them and breathe.

Here was what she had.

He had not flinched at *Sarah*. He had not flinched at *the market stand*, or at *nine years ago*, or at *the old quarry*. He had taken his cap off. He had been sorry, and it had not looked like anything but sorry.

Either Wilmer Graber had had nothing to do with her sister.

Or he was a man who could hold his cap in his hands and be sorry to a dead girl's sister on a Tuesday morning and then eat his dinner.

And Rebecca had no way at all of telling those two men apart. That was the thing she had not understood until she was in the yard with him: she had come out here with the private conviction that she would *know*. That a person could stand in front of it and feel the shape of it.

She had felt nothing. She had liked him.

The horse picked his way over the ice and the trees went by, and Rebecca thought about the second line under the English on the sign, and about a man shouting across a yard in a language nobody in Willow Creek spoke, and about five sets of initials with the numbers going down through the summer.

Then she thought about the one thing in the entire conversation that she could actually check.

My wife'd know. She buys the chow-chow.

The Zooks kept the stand's ledger. Every stand kept a ledger: who bought what, who owed, who paid at the end of the month. Nine years of them, in a box in a back room, because Amish families did not throw out a ledger.

Rebecca clicked her tongue at the horse and put him into a trot on the flat, and did not go home.

The Ledger at the Stand

Barbara Zook was seventy-one and had run the stand on Route 340 for thirty-four years, and she kept her books the way she kept everything else, which was completely and forever.

"You'll want the winter of that year, or the summer?"

"The summer," Rebecca said. "And into the autumn, if there is one."

"There's always one." Barbara set the lamp on the table in the back room and began pulling the boxes down off the shelf with the flat competence of a woman half her age. "I've every year since 'ninety-one. Elam says burn them. I say when I'm dead he can burn what he likes."

Rebecca had come in on a pretext that had lasted about ninety seconds (Lydia's ankles, the cousin coming in April, the general question of who was expecting) before Barbara Zook had looked at her over her glasses and said, "You're not here about ankles."

And Rebecca, who had been in the district her whole life and knew exactly how far she would get lying to this particular woman, had said: "No. I'm here about Sarah."

Barbara had gone still for a moment. Then she had said, "Well. It's about time somebody was," and had gone to get the lamp.

The ledger for that year was a school exercise book, which gave Rebecca a moment of vertigo when she saw it. Same size. Same soft cover, brown instead of blue. Sold at the same store in Gap for the same forty cents.

Barbara turned it around on the table so it faced Rebecca and opened it at June.

"There. The girls' days are in the left margin. S for your Sarah, M for my Mary, both if it was a Saturday."

The margin ran down the page in Barbara Zook's small square hand.

Th: S

Sa: S, M

Th: S

Sa: S, M

Rebecca turned the page. July. The same. August: the same, the same, the same, and then:

She stopped.

Th 8/17: S

And after it, for the rest of August, and September, and October, and November, and December, every Thursday in the margin was blank or held an *M*, and Sarah's initial did not appear on a Thursday again.

Not once.

It appeared on Saturdays. All through the autumn: *Sa: S, M*, *Sa: S, M*, right through to the middle of December when the stand shut for the winter. She had gone on working. She had simply stopped working Thursdays.

Rebecca put her finger on the seventeenth of August and did not move it.

"She changed her day," she said.

"She did."

"When?"

"That week. That very week." Barbara Zook sat down across the table and folded her hands. "She came to me on the Thursday at closing and asked could she come Saturdays instead. I said Saturdays I've Mary and I don't need two, and she said she'd work the Saturday for what I paid for a Thursday, which is less, and I said that's a foolish bargain for you, girl, and she said she didn't mind."

"Did she say why?"

"I asked. She said the Thursday didn't suit any more."

"That's all?"

"That's all, and I let it be, because it was her business." Barbara's mouth tightened. "I've thought about that a great deal since, if you want the truth of it. There's not a year gone by I've not thought about it."

Rebecca looked at the margin, at the *S* that stopped.

"Was she frightened?"

Barbara Zook took her time.

"No," she said at last. "That's the thing I'd tell you if you asked me a hundred times. She wasn't frightened. She was — " she moved a hand, hunting the word " — settled. Like a person who's decided something and is easier for having decided it. She'd been off for weeks before that. Snappish. Watching the road. And then that Thursday she came and asked me about the Saturdays and after that she was herself again."

Settled.

Rebecca thought of a girl writing *ask him what he tells them it is for* at the bottom of a page, and then closing a notebook, and then walking to a woman she had worked for since she was fifteen and calmly arranging never to be there on a Thursday again.

Not frightened. Finished with something.

"There's one more thing," said Barbara, "and I couldn't tell you if it means anything at all."

"Tell me anyway."

"She asked to be paid up. That same evening. Everything owing from the first of the month, in the hand, that night." Barbara shook her head. "I'd never had a girl ask me that in thirty years. They wait for the end of the month like everybody. I said, Sarah, is there trouble at home, is your father short — and she said no, and she looked me in the eye when she said it, and I gave her her money."

"How much?"

"It'd be in the book." Barbara turned two pages back and ran her finger down. "Twenty-two dollars and fifty. Sixteen days at — yes. Twenty-two fifty."

Rebecca wrote it in her ledger, under the copied pages, in the space she had left blank.

8/17, paid out to S, 22.50. Asked for it that night.

She stayed another hour, because Barbara Zook had not talked about Sarah in nine years and it turned out that she had a great deal she had not been able to say.

Most of it was not useful. Sarah had been quick at the till and hopeless at folding. Sarah had once sold a quilt to a woman from Delaware for eleven dollars over the asking price and had been insufferable about it for a fortnight. Sarah had liked the tour buses, which the other girls hated, because she liked hearing where people had come from.

Some of it was.

"She talked to the men from the pit," Barbara said. "That's not a thing I'd have said to the trooper, mind, because he'd have made something ugly of it and there was nothing ugly in it. They came down at noon, three or four of them, for the pies. She had a little Spanish — I've no idea where she got it — and she'd try it on them and they'd laugh at her and correct her, and she'd write it down on the back of the order pad."

Rebecca had gone very still.

"She wrote it down."

"Words. Just words. *Bread*. *Two dollars*. *Thank you*." Barbara half smiled. "She was that sort. Everything on paper."

"Did the older one come? Efrain."

"You know Efrain?"

"I know the name."

"He came. He was the one corrected her." Barbara's smile went out. "That was the summer they got their wages cut, or something of the sort. I never had the whole of it. But they stopped buying the pies in the July and started bringing their own, and Sarah was cross about it for a week, and I told her it was no business of hers what a man ate for his dinner."

"Was it wages?"

"I don't know what it was."

"Barbara." Rebecca kept her voice level with an effort that cost her something. "Did she ever say the name Graber to you?"

Barbara Zook looked at her for a long moment across the lamp.

"His wife buys my chow-chow," she said. "Every month. She's a pleasant woman. She lost a boy at four years old, before you were born."

"That's not what I asked."

"I know what you asked." The old woman's hands were flat on the table now. "And I'll tell you what I know, which is nothing, and then I'll tell you what I think, and you'll have the sense to keep them apart. What I know is that your sister worked Thursdays and then wouldn't, and asked for her money, and was easier after. What I *think* — "

She stopped.

"Say it."

"What I think," said Barbara Zook, "is that a girl of seventeen doesn't arrange to be somewhere else on one particular day of the week because of a thing she read in a book. She does it because of a person. And the person will be someone she saw on Thursdays and not on Saturdays."

The lamp hissed.

"And who did she see on Thursdays," Rebecca said, "and not on Saturdays?"

"On a Thursday," said Barbara, "the pit pays its men."

Rebecca drove home in the dark with her lantern lit and her mind entirely quiet, which was not calm.

It was the quiet of a room after something has been set down in it.

The pit pays its men on Thursday.

Sarah had stood at that stand every Thursday for nine and a half months and watched something happen four hundred yards up the road, and had written down what she saw, week after week, in the margins of shoofly pie.

And then on the seventeenth of August she had written a sentence instead of a number, and had gone to Barbara Zook and arranged never to be there on payday again, and had asked for every dollar she was owed that same night.

Not frightened. Settled.

A girl who has decided something.

Rebecca turned in at her own lane and got down to open the gate, and stood for a second in the cold with her hand on the wet wood.

Five months. From the seventeenth of August to the sixteenth of January. Five months in which Sarah Yoder had done nothing at all, so far as anyone had ever known. She had gone to church, and folded quilts on Saturdays, and been quiet at supper on the fifteenth, and asked her sister a question about their mother and then said *never mind*.

Five months was not the shape of a girl who had run away from something.

It was the shape of a girl who had been waiting for something.

A Detective, Concerning Tools

The police came to Willow Creek about a generator.

It was, in the end, a very ordinary crime. Somebody had been going through the outbuildings of the district for six weeks: a generator from the Hostetlers, a chop saw and two chains from Amos Kauffman's shop, a pressure washer, and finally a whole toolbox out of the back of Enos Lapp's spring wagon while he was at church.

Nobody had reported any of it.

That was not obstruction. It was simply how it was done: you did not go to the law over property. You told the bishop, and the bishop told the district, and the district watched, and the men rebuilt what could be rebuilt and did without the rest. In three of the four cases the neighbors had replaced the tools within a fortnight without being asked.

But Enos Lapp's toolbox had been insured, because Enos did work for *Englisch* contractors and had been made to insure it, and the insurance company would not pay without a police report, and so on the last Wednesday in January a county car came up the Lapps' lane and a woman in a wool coat got out of it with a clipboard.

Rebecca was in the kitchen with Katie and the baby, doing the six-week check.

Detective Marla Cruz was somewhere in her forties, with a gray streak she had not troubled to hide and the general air of a person who had done a great deal of paperwork that morning and expected to do more that afternoon.

She was, Rebecca noticed, careful at the door. She waited to be asked in. She looked at Katie's *kapp* and then did not look at it again.

"Mrs. Lapp. I'm sorry to come out over a toolbox."

"It's my husband's."

"I know. He's out at the barn, he sent me in to get warm and to ask if you'd got any coffee, which I think means he wants five minutes to think about what he's going to tell me." Cruz said it perfectly pleasantly. Katie Lapp, who had not smiled at a stranger in Rebecca's presence in five years, laughed.

Rebecca packed her bag slowly.

"You're the midwife," Cruz said to her.

"I am."

"You get around the whole district, then."

"Most of it."

"Anybody mention hearing a vehicle at night? Between, say, the middle of December and now."

"Two people," said Rebecca. "Naomi Esh, who's eighty-three and deaf and hears a great many things. And Lydia Zook, who heard a truck idling on the Kinzers road about ten at night, some time before Christmas, and thought it was her brother-in-law and it wasn't."

Marla Cruz stopped writing and looked up.

"That's the most useful thirty seconds I've had in this township in six weeks."

"You'd have got it from Lydia if you'd asked her."

"I'd have got it from Lydia if Lydia had opened the door," said Cruz, "which she didn't, on Monday, though I could see her through the window."

Rebecca said nothing to that, because there was nothing to say to it that was not either a lie or a disloyalty.

Cruz seemed to understand. She wrote for a moment.

"You've kept records," she said. "Of your work. Have you."

"Nine years of them."

"Dates, addresses, times of night?"

"Dates, addresses, times of night, weights, and who was in the house."

Cruz put her pen down.

"Ms. Yoder, if it turns out our friend with the truck has been working nights on a schedule, you have the only continuous record of who was awake and where in this entire township, and I'd very much like to buy you a coffee about it."

"I'd not be able to give you the names of the families."

"I wouldn't ask for them. I'd ask which nights you were out and on which roads."

Rebecca considered this and found, somewhat to her own surprise, that she did not mind it.

"That I could do."

Enos came in, and the coffee was made, and the business of the toolbox took twenty minutes: serial numbers, the value, the date, the fact that the wagon had been standing in the lane from eight until half past twelve.

Then Cruz did a thing Rebecca had not expected. She closed the clipboard, put it on the table, and said to Enos: "Mr. Lapp, may I ask you something that isn't about your tools?"

Enos looked wary. "You may ask."

"I've been in and out of this township for six weeks and four separate people have told me about a girl who drowned. Nobody brought it up on purpose. It comes up sideways — I asked a man for directions to the Hostetler place and he told me not to go past the old quarry in the dark, and then he told me why." She turned her mug on the table. "That's not normal. I've worked townships for eighteen years. A nine-year-old accident doesn't come up four times in six weeks unless it isn't finished."

The kitchen was quiet.

Rebecca kept her hands on her bag and did not look up.

"It was an accident," Enos said.

"That's what the file says."

"You've read the file?"

"I pulled it Tuesday, out of curiosity, which my lieutenant would tell you is how detectives waste a county's money." Cruz's face did something complicated. "It's a thin file. That's not an accusation. Accidents make thin files, that's what they're for."

"But," said Rebecca.

She had not meant to speak.

Marla Cruz turned and looked at her with a directness that Rebecca had not encountered from anyone in a long time.

"But there are four girls interviewed and one boy," Cruz said, "and no one else. And the quarry sits between two properties, and there's a fence contractor's yard on one side of it and a stone operation a couple of miles the other way, and in January of that year both of them would have had men working. And there isn't a single seasonal worker in that file. Not one. Not interviewed, not listed, not ruled out."

"They wouldn't have been there in January," said Enos. "The pit shuts."

"The pit shuts in December and starts again the first week of March. I checked this morning." Cruz shrugged. "Which is a good answer and it's probably the right one. But somebody should have written the good answer down, and nobody did, and that's the part that makes me itch."

She picked up the clipboard again.

"Anyway. It's not my case, it's not open, and it's nine years old, and I've a generator to find. Forget I said it."

"Why did you say it?" Rebecca asked.

Cruz stopped with her coat half on.

"Because the man who gave me directions cried," she said. "Standing in the road. A man of about sixty, telling a stranger about somebody else's daughter. And I've been doing this a long time and that's not what a township looks like when a thing is over."

Rebecca followed her out to the car.

She had not decided to. She was aware of doing it, in the same way she had been aware of putting the silver clip in her apron instead of the box.

"Detective."

Cruz turned with the door open.

"If a person had a question about that file," Rebecca said, "and did not want it to be a matter of the district, who would they ask?"

Marla Cruz looked at her across the roof of the car for a good three seconds.

Then she took out a card, wrote a number on the back of it, and held it out.

"That's the desk. This — " she tapped the back " — is my cell. The desk gets answered by whoever's nearest and it goes in a log."

Rebecca took the card and did not look at it.

"I've not said I have a question."

"No," Cruz agreed. "You haven't."

She got in and started the engine, and then put the window down.

"Ms. Yoder. I don't know how any of this works out here — I want to say that plainly, because I've watched two colleagues make fools of themselves in this township by pretending they did." Her breath showed in the cold. "But I know what it looks like when somebody's been carrying a thing on their own for a long time. It looks exactly like you look."

She drove out down the lane.

Rebecca stood in the Lapps' yard with a business card in her hand and the whole flat gray weight of the afternoon on her, and after a moment she put the card in her apron pocket, in the same pocket, and it lay there against her hip all the way home like something warm.

Two Women, Neither of Them Fluent

They met at the Dutch Kitchen in Gap, which was a compromise neither of them named out loud: an *Englisch* restaurant where Amish women went, on a road where being seen was ordinary.

Rebecca got there first and took the booth at the back with her ledger in her bag and her hands around a cup of coffee she did not want.

Marla Cruz came in at ten past two with snow on her shoulders, saw her, and did something that surprised Rebecca considerably: she stopped at the counter, said something to the girl there, and came over with two slices of pie she had not been asked to bring.

"Shoofly," she said, setting one down. "I've been informed by three separate people in this county that I can't understand anything about anybody here until I've eaten it, so I'm eating it under protest."

"It's very sweet."

"So I'm told."

She sat. She took her coat off. Under it she was wearing an ordinary sweater, and Rebecca understood, with a small internal adjustment, that the detective had thought about what to wear.

"Right," said Cruz. "Ground rules, because I'd rather set them than trip over them. One: I'm not recording this and I'm not taking a statement. Two: if you tell me something that makes this a criminal matter, I have to act on it, and I'll tell you before I do, not after. Three: if at any point you want to stop, we stop, and I don't come back to your house about it."

"That's more than I expected."

"It's less than it sounds. Number two is the one that matters and people always hear it last." Cruz picked up her fork. "Now. Your ledgers."

Rebecca took the work ledger out of her bag and set it on the table between them, closed.

"I'll tell you which nights I was out and which roads I drove," she said. "Not who. Not where."

"Understood."

"If it turns out one of them was a family with a thing worth stealing, and you go to them because I said I was on that road — "

"Then you'll never speak to me again and you'll be right." Cruz put her fork down. "Ms. Yoder, I've worked two townships like this. What ends it, every time, is the moment somebody works out that talking to me got their neighbor a visit. I know exactly how expensive this is for you. I'm not going to spend it on a generator."

Rebecca opened the ledger.

It took forty minutes and it was, in the end, useful in a way neither of them had expected.

Rebecca read out dates and roads. Cruz wrote, and asked, twice, whether Rebecca was certain of a time, and both times Rebecca was, because the times were written down at the moment they happened by a woman who had been paid to be exact about them for nine years.

At the end Cruz sat back and looked at her list.

"You were on the Kinzers road at eleven forty on the eighth of December and there was nothing. You were on it again at two in the morning on the nineteenth and there was a truck parked in the pull-off by the culvert with no lights."

"There was."

"You didn't think that worth mentioning to anybody."

"I thought it was somebody meeting somebody," said Rebecca, "which is the usual reason for a truck in a pull-off at two in the morning, and it wasn't my business, and I'd a woman in labor a mile up the road."

Cruz laughed, one short breath through the nose.

"Fair. That's the nineteenth. The Kauffman shop was done on the twentieth." She tapped the page. "That's the first hard thing anyone's given me. Thank you."

"You're welcome."

"Now." Cruz closed her notebook and put it in her bag, deliberately, where Rebecca could see it go. "That's the toolboxes done. Say the other thing."

Rebecca looked at the pie she had not touched.

The whole way here she had rehearsed an approach: something careful, something that gave away the least. She had got as far as *a person might have found some papers* twice in her head and had known both times how it would sound.

"My sister kept a notebook," she said. "For nine and a half months before she died. It looks like recipes. In the margins it's dates and initials and money, every Thursday, and I think it's a record of a man taking wages off men who couldn't complain about it."

Marla Cruz did not move.

"Go on."

"The last entry is the seventeenth of August. Underneath it she wrote *ask him what he tells them it is for*. That's the last thing in it." Rebecca made herself keep her voice at the level she used for reporting a birth. "That same evening she went to the woman who ran the market stand and arranged never to work Thursdays again, at less money, and asked to be paid everything she was owed that night. Then she went on living here for five months and said nothing to anyone, and then she drowned."

The restaurant clattered around them.

"Where's the notebook now?" Cruz said.

"Somewhere it won't be found."

"Have you got it with you?"

"No."

"Good." Cruz let out a breath. "Don't bring it to me."

Rebecca had braced for a great many responses and not that one.

"Why not?"

"Because the second you hand me a document, it's evidence in a nine-year-old closed accidental death that nobody has asked me to reopen, and I have to book it, and then it belongs to the county, and then it goes where I can't reach it and neither can you." Cruz leaned forward. "Listen to me carefully, because this is the part people get wrong. Right now you have a thing, and I have a curiosity, and neither of us has done anything official. That's not weakness. That's the only room we've got."

"So what do I do with it?"

"Copy it. Twice. Put one copy somewhere that isn't your house."

"I've copied it once."

"Then you're ahead of most people I deal with." Cruz turned her cup around.

"Second thing. The initials. Have you got a name."

Rebecca thought about lying and understood that she had no reason to and no talent for it.

"I've got a guess," she said. "The market stand is four hundred yards from the entrance to a stone pit. The pit pays its men on Thursdays. The initials that appear in every single entry are W.G."

Cruz did not write it down. Rebecca noticed that she very deliberately did not write it down.

"All right," she said.

"That's all? *All right*?"

"That's all, because a set of initials in a dead girl's recipe book is not a thing, Ms. Yoder — it's a reason to look for a thing." Cruz spread her hands. "Here's what I can't do. I can't go and speak to a man on the strength of that. I can't pull his books. I can't ask the state about his payroll. I've no case, no complainant, no offense reported inside the statute, and the moment I asked I'd be telling him somebody was asking."

"Then what's the use of any of it?"

"Did I say there was no use?" Cruz said. "There's one thing that would change everything, and it isn't paper."

"What?"

"A man," said Marla Cruz. "One of them. One man who was there that summer and can stand up and say *I was paid forty and I received twenty-five and here is who handed it to me.* That's not a nine-year-old drowning any more. That's wage theft, and if he did it to five men over a season it's a pattern, and a pattern gets a warrant, and a warrant gets everything else." She sat back. "The whole thing turns on whether one of those five men is still findable and still willing. Everything else is a recipe book."

Rebecca sat very still.

Efrain, she thought. *Efrain, who corrected her Spanish. Efrain, whose son's wife is expecting in two months.*

She had a sudden and entirely unwelcome image of herself standing in a yard asking a man to destroy his own life for her sister.

"And if that man has no papers," she said slowly, "and asking him to speak means asking him to lose everything he has?"

Marla Cruz was quiet for a moment.

"Then you'd be asking him for something you have no right to ask for," she said. "And I'd be asking too, and I'd have less right than you."

"That's not an answer."

"No," Cruz agreed. "It isn't. I haven't got one. I've been doing this eighteen years and that particular question has never once had a clean answer, and anybody who tells you different is selling something."

She put money on the table for the coffee and the pie, both slices, and stood and pulled her coat on.

"Ms. Yoder. One more thing and then I'll go, and you can decide whether you ever call me."

"Go on."

"You said she went on living here for five months and said nothing." Cruz buttoned her coat. "That's the part I'd think about, if I were you. Not the notebook. Not the initials. Five months is a long time for a seventeen-year-old to sit on something. Either she'd decided to let it go — "

"She hadn't."

" — or she was waiting for something to happen. And in my experience," said Marla Cruz, "when a young person waits five months, they're usually waiting for somebody. Somebody they'd told."

She went out into the snow.

Rebecca sat in the booth with two slices of shoofly pie in front of her and did not move for a long time.

Somebody they'd told.

And in nine years, in all the turning over and the counting and the four readings of a thin file, that possibility had never once crossed her mind: that her sister had not been alone with it.

The One She Told

She went to Daniel because there was nobody else.

That was the honest accounting of it, and Rebecca made herself do the accounting before she went, sitting in the buggy shed on the upturned crate with the candle out and the cold coming through her coat.

Who would a seventeen-year-old girl in this district tell?

Not her mother. Sarah and Miriam had loved each other in the manner of the house, which was thoroughly and without discussion, and a girl does not bring that to a mother who will take it to the bishop before supper.

Not the bishop.

Not her sister. Rebecca had had nine years to be sure of that one and was sure. Sarah had asked her a question at the sink about whether their mother had ever wanted to be something else, and Rebecca had let it go, and that had been the whole of what she was offered.

Not Emma Stoltzfus, or Lena, or the Beiler girls, because Sarah had gone on being ordinary with all of them for five months and girls of seventeen cannot do that.

Which left one person in Willow Creek who had been at the quarry that night, had never given a good account of twenty minutes, had gone to the world two months later and stayed there for nine years, and had come back saying he wanted to be forgiven for not looking for her.

Or, Rebecca thought, *it left nobody, and I am building a road to a man I want to walk toward.*

She wrote both possibilities down in the back of her work ledger, in pencil, because writing a thing down was the only way she had ever found to stop it turning into whatever she wanted it to be.

Then she went.

He was in his mother's woodshed, and he was not pretending to work.

That was the first difference. He had a plane in his hand and a length of oak in the vise and a curl of shaving coming off it thin enough to see through, and there was a stack of finished pieces against the wall that meant he had been at it for days.

"That's not fence work," Rebecca said from the doorway.

Daniel looked up. "No."

"What is it?"

"Corner cupboard. For my mother's kitchen, which she doesn't want and doesn't need." He blew the shaving off. "The bishop's given me till the spring communion before he'll say anything about instruction. Three months of being looked at. A man can't do that with his hands empty."

"So you're making a cupboard nobody wants."

"I'm making a cupboard nobody wants," Daniel agreed, "very slowly."

He set the plane down. He had a way of putting a tool down that Rebecca had noticed at the fence and noticed again now: he put it where it went, every time, without looking.

"You've come about something," he said.

"I have."

"Then come in out of the door. You're letting the cold in and there's not much heat in here to start with."

She told him.

Not all of it. She held back the bishop, and the sawdust on the join, and Cruz. But she told him the box, and the notebook, and eleven pages of Thursdays, and the market stand four hundred yards from a gate, and what Barbara Zook had said about a girl who changed her day and was easier after.

Daniel Beiler listened the way she had not heard anybody listen in nine years, which was: entirely, and without preparing what he was going to say.

When she stopped he was quiet for a long moment.

"You've had this how long?"

"Three weeks."

"And you've carried it alone for three weeks."

"I've carried the other thing alone for nine years," said Rebecca. "Three weeks is nothing."

Daniel turned and put both hands flat on the bench and leaned on them and looked at the wall.

"Ask me," he said.

"Ask you what?"

"The thing you came to ask. You've been standing there ten minutes working out how to get to it." He turned around. "I'd rather you just said it, Rebecca. I've had nine years of people not saying things."

So she said it.

"Did she tell you?"

"No."

"Daniel — "

"*No.*" He said it without heat. "And I've thought about it, since you started — since I saw your face at the fence, I've thought of nothing else. If Sarah Yoder had told me that a man was robbing his workmen, I'd have been seventeen and stupid and I'd have gone up that lane and put a window in. That's what I was. That's exactly what I was." His jaw worked. "She'd have known that. That's likely why she didn't."

Rebecca stood in the cold shed and felt something she had been holding onto come apart quietly.

"Then there's nobody," she said.

"I didn't say that."

"You just — "

"I said she didn't tell *me*." Daniel picked up the shaving from the bench and turned it over in his fingers. "I said that. Now let me tell you what I do know, which I've never told a living soul, because for nine years there was nobody I could tell it to who wouldn't have made it into something."

Rebecca did not breathe.

"That autumn," Daniel said, "she asked me about the bus."

"The bus."

"The Trailways out of Gap. Where it went. What it cost. Whether you needed anything to get on it besides money." He looked up. "I knew because I'd been

pricing it myself since the summer. Everybody in *rumspringa* knows the bus. It's the only thing we all know."

"When?"

"November. Middle of November — it was cold, and we were behind the Stoltzfus barn at a singing, and she came and stood next to me and asked how much to Philadelphia and whether the driver asked for a name." He set the shaving down very carefully. "I told her nineteen dollars and no, nobody asks for a name."

Twenty-two dollars and fifty cents. Asked for it that night. In the hand.

Rebecca put out a hand and held the edge of the bench.

"She was going to run."

"That's what I thought at the time. I thought she was going to run and I thought — " his mouth twisted " — I thought maybe she'd want company, and I spent a week being pleased with myself about it, at seventeen, and then nothing happened. She never mentioned it again. And in January she was dead and I went to the world in March and I have never once said that sentence out loud until this minute."

"Why not?"

"Because *she asked about the bus* is a thing a person can turn into anything they like." Daniel's voice was rough now. "The trooper would have made it a runaway girl who slipped on the ice. My father would have made it my fault for telling her. Her mother — " He stopped. "I was seventeen and the whole district was looking at me and I had already failed to give them twenty minutes. I wasn't going to hand them that as well."

The shed was very quiet.

"You should have told me," said Rebecca.

"You were nineteen and you couldn't look at me."

That was true. She remembered it exactly: standing at the graveside and knowing that Daniel Beiler was six people to her left and being unable to turn her head.

"You should have told me anyway," she said.

"Yes," said Daniel. "I should have told you anyway."

She got as far as the gate.

Then she stopped with her hand on the horse's cheekpiece and worked it through, because something in it did not sit right and she had learned not to leave those alone.

November. Sarah had asked about the bus in the middle of November.

But the notebook had stopped on the seventeenth of August, and she had taken her money that same night, and had arranged never to be at the stand on a Thursday again.

Three months apart.

If she had been running, she would have gone in August. You do not take your wages in your hand in August and then wait until the middle of November to ask what the ticket costs, and then wait another two months, and then go to a quarry with your friends on a Wednesday night in January.

Unless.

Rebecca stood in the Beilers' lane with the cold going through her and finally saw the shape of it, and it was not the shape of a girl running away.

It was the shape of a girl who had decided to go, and who was waiting until she could take somebody with her.

Somebody who could not simply get on a bus.

Somebody with no papers, five names in a notebook, and fifteen dollars a week going out of his pocket into another man's.

She turned around and went back up the lane, and Daniel was still standing in the shed doorway watching her go, and he straightened when he saw her coming.

"I need to find a man called Efrain," Rebecca said.

What Efrain Kept

It took nine days and it was Daniel who found him, which Rebecca had not expected and which turned out to be obvious once it had happened: a man who had spent nine years working *Englisch* jobs in Philadelphia knew how to ask questions in places where an Amish woman in a *kapp* could not go without becoming the news of the week.

He came up her lane on the Thursday evening with his hat in his hand and said, "Kinzers. Behind the tire place. He's called Efrain Mendez and he's been in this county eleven years and he does not want to talk to you."

"You've spoken to him."

"I've spoken to his son. Who told me, politely, that his father is fifty-eight years old and has a bad shoulder and a granddaughter coming in April, and asked me what I thought a police report was going to do for any of that." Daniel turned the hat over. "He wasn't wrong, Rebecca."

"No."

"I said we'd come Saturday if he'd have us. He said he'd think."

"*We*?"

"You'd not find the house," said Daniel, "and if you went alone you'd be a woman from the church arriving at his door, which is a thing that has meant trouble for him before. If I'm there it's two people who want something, which is at least honest."

The house was the back half of a divided rental behind a tire shop on the Kinzers road, and Efrain Mendez met them on the step rather than inviting them in, which Rebecca understood and did not resent.

He was not a big man. Gray at the temples, a work jacket over a sweater, one shoulder held higher than the other in the way of a joint that has been wrong for years. He looked at Daniel and then at Rebecca, and at the *kapp*, and something in his face closed by about a third.

"You're the sister," he said. His English was accented and completely fluent.

"I am."

"Everyone knew who she was. After." He put his hands in his jacket pockets. "I am sorry for it. I said so then, to no one, because there was no one to say it to."

"May I ask you about that summer?"

"You may ask."

He did not say *and I will answer*. Rebecca marked that.

"She wrote things down," she said. "In a book. Dates and letters and money."

Efrain Mendez looked at her for a long moment.

"Yes," he said. "I know."

They talked on the step for forty minutes in the cold, and he did not once invite them in, and Rebecca came to understand that this was not rudeness but arithmetic: a conversation on a step could be ended.

He told it plainly and without drama, which made it worse.

The pit paid cash on Thursdays. That was normal. Half the seasonal work in the county paid cash. The rate was agreed at forty a day, and for the first two seasons that was what came, and Efrain had thought it a fair place, better than the mushroom houses, and had brought his nephew.

Then in the spring of that year there had begun to be a deduction.

"For the papers," he said. "He said it was for the man who does the papers. The permit, the tax, the — I don't know the word. He said, *this is what it costs to keep you working here, and I pay it, and you pay me back.*"

"And was there such a man?"

"There is always such a man somewhere." Efrain shrugged with one shoulder, the good one. "Maybe there is. Maybe there was once. I did not ask, because to ask is to say *I think you are stealing*, and then next Thursday there is no work for you, and there is no one to say why."

"How much?"

"It began at ten. Then fifteen. Then it was twenty and there were four of us and then five." He looked at the yard. "The last month I worked fifty-five hours and I brought home what I brought home in a good week the year before."

"Did you complain?"

"To who?" He said it without bitterness, as a genuine question, and waited to see whether she had an answer.

She did not.

"The girl," he said after a moment. "Sarah. She sold the pies."

"Yes."

"She was learning Spanish, badly." A very small smile went across his face and did not stay. "*Buenos días, señor, dos dólares, gracias.* Terrible. Terrible. We corrected her and she wrote it down and next week she said it wrong again in a different way."

"Barbara Zook said you stopped buying the pies."

"In July we stopped buying anything." He said it flatly. "That week I told the boys, no more. We bring bread. And the girl came out to the road to ask why we did not come any more, and I said, because a pie is a dollar fifty, and she looked at me and she did not say anything foolish. She did not say *oh, that is sad*. She went back inside."

Rebecca said, "And then?"

"And then the next week she came out again and she asked me a question." Efrain Mendez took his hands out of his pockets. "She asked me what I was paid and what I received."

The cold came up off the concrete step.

"And you told her."

"I told her." His voice did not change. "I have thought about that many times. Eight years, nine years. She was a child in an apron and she asked me a straight question, and no one had asked me a straight question in a year, and I answered it. Forty and twenty. That is all. Two numbers."

"You couldn't have known —"

"I could have known that nothing good comes from talking," said Efrain. "That I knew. That I had known since I was younger than she was."

Rebecca took the muslin out of her bag then, because there was no better moment and there was not going to be one.

She unwrapped it on her palm: the silver clip, the scrollwork, the three small blue stones.

"This was in her things," she said. "It's not Amish. She had it hidden."

Efrain Mendez went absolutely still.

Then he sat down on the step, slowly, holding the rail, like a man whose legs had been taken out from under him in a manner he had not been given warning of.

"*Ay*," he said. And then something else, in Spanish, that Rebecca did not understand and did not need to.

Daniel put a hand out and did not quite touch his shoulder.

"It was my daughter's," Efrain said.

"Your daughter's."

"Rosa." He did not look up from it. "She is in Reading now, she has two children, she is fine. She was nineteen and she worked the summer at the pit office, the papers, the — she can type, she was always the clever one." He wiped his face with the back of his hand, once, impatiently. "This was her *quinceañera*. From her grandmother. She lost it that August and she cried for a week and I told her, things go, *m'ija*, things go."

"Where did she lose it?"

"She said the office."

Rebecca knelt down on the step so that she was not standing over him.

"Efrain," she said. "Why would Sarah Yoder have your daughter's hair clip, wrapped in cloth, hidden in a box under a handkerchief?"

Efrain Mendez looked at the clip in her hand for a long, long moment.

"Because somebody gave it to her," he said. "Or because she took it from somewhere it should not have been."

"Where should it not have been?"

He did not answer that.

He stood up, using the rail, and he was a fifty-eight-year-old man with a bad shoulder and a granddaughter coming in April, and Rebecca watched him make a calculation she had no right to watch and no right at all to influence.

"You want me to talk to the police," he said.

"I want to know what happened to my sister."

"That is not the same thing, and you know it is not." He looked at her steadily. "If I talk, they look at me. They look at my son. They look at everything. And the

man — he has a lawyer, he has twenty-six years here, he has a wife who buys chow-chow from the Amish. And I have a step."

"I know."

"Do you?"

"No," said Rebecca. "I don't. I've never once had to know a thing like that, and I'd be lying if I said otherwise."

Something in Efrain's face eased fractionally, not warmth, but a kind of recognition.

"Leave me the winter," he said. "The baby comes in April. After that — " he made a gesture that meant nothing and everything " — after that, ask me again."

"That's four months."

"Yes."

"She's been dead nine years."

"Then four months will not hurt her," said Efrain Mendez, "and it may not ruin me."

He went inside and shut the door, and Rebecca stood in the yard behind a tire shop with a dead girl's arithmetic in her bag and a stranger's daughter's hair clip in her hand.

"Rebecca," Daniel said quietly.

"I know."

"He said *or she took it from somewhere it should not have been.*"

"I *know*," said Rebecca.

Because there was only one place in this entire story where a clever nineteen-year-old girl who could type had lost a silver clip in August, and only one reason a seventeen-year-old with a notebook full of stolen wages would have gone into that place and come out with it.

Sarah had not been waiting five months for someone to help her.

She had been collecting.

The Forgiveness Already Given

The second summons was not casual.

The first had come sideways, through Ammon at the gate, in the way of a man who would be glad if she stopped in. This one came on a Tuesday morning in the person of Amos Stoltzfus himself, in his own buggy, up the Yoders' lane, at nine o'clock, which meant that every soul on that road saw him go up it and would know by dinner that the bishop had driven out to Miriam Yoder's.

Rebecca watched him come from the kitchen window and knew, with a calm that surprised her, that this was the day.

Her mother knew too. Miriam had gone very quiet at the sink.

"Shall I go out to him?" Rebecca said.

"He'll come in." Miriam did not turn round. "He'll want the table."

He wanted the table.

He sat where the bishop always sat, at the end nearest the door, and he took the coffee Miriam gave him and did not drink it, and he waited while she found something to do at the far end of the kitchen. Not leaving, because a woman does not leave her own kitchen, and not sitting either.

"Rebecca," said Amos Stoltzfus. "You've been to Kinzers."

She had prepared herself for a number of openings. Not that one.

"I have."

"To a Mexican family behind the tire shop, with Daniel Beiler, on a Saturday." He said it without any emphasis at all, which was worse than emphasis. "And before that to Barbara Zook, about the ledgers of her stand. And before that to the stone pit on 340, where you asked Wilmer Graber about the wives of his men."

The kitchen was completely silent.

"You've had me followed," Rebecca said.

"No." He looked genuinely pained. "*No.* Child. Nobody in this district would do such a thing and nobody had to. Barbara Zook told her son what you'd asked and her son told his wife. The Kinzers house is three doors from where Levi King's boy works and he saw Daniel's hat. And Wilmer Graber — "

He stopped.

"Wilmer Graber told you himself," said Rebecca.

Amos Stoltzfus turned his cup a quarter turn on the table.

"He rang the phone at the mill," he said. "On the Thursday. He said a young woman of ours had come to his yard and asked after his men, and he wanted me to know he'd been glad to help her, and that if the church needed anything from him he'd be glad to be asked properly." His mouth was tight. "He was pleasant about it. He is always pleasant about it."

Something cold went through Rebecca and settled.

He is always pleasant about it.

"You know," she said.

"Rebecca — "

"You know. That's not a man you've met twice at the feed store. That's a man you have had dealings with, and you knew what I was doing in his yard the minute you heard I'd been in it."

"Miriam," said the bishop, not looking away from Rebecca, "sit down."

And Rebecca's mother, who had run that kitchen for thirty years, sat down.

"I'll tell you what I can," Amos Stoltzfus said, "and you'll find it isn't much, and you'll be angry. I'd rather you were angry at the truth than satisfied with something else."

"Then tell me."

"In the spring after your sister died, a man came to me and confessed a sin." He said it steadily. "He came of his own will. He was in a state I have seen perhaps four times in nineteen years. He confessed, and he repented, and he was given penance, and he was forgiven — and the matter was closed, before God and before the church, and it will not be opened by me."

The clock on the shelf.

"Who," said Rebecca.

"I will not tell you that."

"Who, Amos."

"I *will not tell you that*." It was the first time in her life she had heard him raise his voice, and it was not loud, and it was terrible. "Do you know what you are asking? You are asking me to take a thing a man said to me on his knees in that shop with the door shut and hand it to you across a kitchen table. If I do that, then no man in this district ever confesses anything to any bishop again, not for a hundred years. The whole of it — all of it, everything we have — rests on a man being able to say the worst thing he has ever done out loud and have it stay where he said it."

"And my sister?"

"Your sister was dead before he ever came to me," said the bishop. "Nothing I heard in that room could have brought her back, and there was no living person it could have protected."

"You don't know that."

"No," he admitted. "I do not know that."

Rebecca gripped the edge of the table.

"Was it Wilmer Graber?"

"I will not — "

"Was it *Daniel Beiler*?"

The bishop stopped.

And Rebecca watched his face, which she had watched all her life, and saw something cross it that she had never seen there before, which was surprise.

"No," said Amos Stoltzfus. "It was not Daniel Beiler."

It came out before he had decided to say it. She knew that. He knew it too. She saw him know it, saw the flicker of a man who has spent nineteen years never once being caught out and has just been caught out by a question he was not braced for.

He put both hands flat on the table.

"That's all you'll have from me," he said quietly. "And I'd have given you that much a week ago if you'd asked it plainly, because that boy has carried something for nine years that was never his, and I have let him, and I'll answer for it."

"You let him," Rebecca said.

"I did."

"He lost his father over it. His father died not speaking to him."

"I know what it cost him." The bishop's voice was low. "I told Daniel at the time, as much as I could — I told him I believed him. I could not tell him why I believed him. A man who knows **why** would not have gone to the world; he'd have stayed and torn the district in half looking for the rest of it, at seventeen, with nothing to go on." He shook his head slowly. "I made a choice. It was mine to make and I made it and I have not slept easy since. But do not tell me I did it lightly."

"And the forgiveness," said Rebecca. "The forgiveness has already been given."

"It has."

"To him. Not to us." She heard her own voice going and did not stop it. "You gave it. You, in a shop with the door shut, on behalf of a girl who was already in the ground and could not be asked. Did anybody ask my mother? Did anybody ask **me**?"

"Rebecca," said Miriam.

"No, **Mamm**."

"Rebecca." Her mother's hand came down flat on the table. "Enough."

And there was something in it, some pitch, some warning, that made Rebecca turn and look at her properly for the first time since the bishop had sat down.

Miriam Yoder was white to the lips.

Not angry. Not shocked.

Waiting. Waiting the way you wait when a thing you have been braced for is finally arriving, and the only question left is from which direction.

Rebecca looked at her mother, and then at the bishop, and then at her mother again, and the kitchen tilted very slightly.

"**Mamm**," she said. "When did you know?"

Miriam did not answer.

"When did you know?"

"Amos," said Miriam Yoder, in a voice like a door closing, "you'll have more coffee or you'll go."

The bishop rose.

He put his hat on and stood for a moment with his hand on the back of the chair, an old man in a kitchen he had sat in for a great many years, and he said, to neither of them exactly:

"There is a right way to do this and I have never found it. In nineteen years I have never once found it." He went to the door. "Rebecca. What you're doing — I

can't stop you. I'd not know how. But I'll ask you to hold one thing in your mind while you do it, and then I'll not say it again."

"Say it."

"The man who confessed to me," said Amos Stoltzfus, "did not confess to killing anybody."

He went out, and they heard the buggy turn in the yard, and the sound of it going down the lane took a long time to fade.

Rebecca stood in her mother's kitchen with her hands still on the table.

Did not confess to killing anybody.

Which meant that whatever had happened in the shop with the door shut, it had been something else: something a man could confess and be forgiven for and go on living two miles away for nine years.

Something less than a death.

And a great deal worse than nothing.

No Locks in an Amish House

They did not speak of it.

That was the thing Rebecca found she could not get over, in the four days that followed: that the bishop's buggy had gone down the lane and her mother had stood up and washed the two coffee cups and said, "You'll want to look in on the Fisher girl before it snows," and the household had closed over the morning like water over a stone.

She let it. That was the part she would examine later with something close to disgust. She let it, because thirty years of that kitchen were in her bones, and because she was afraid of what would come out if she pushed, and because (she was honest enough to know this) she wanted to have the rest of it in her hands before she asked her mother a question she could not un-ask.

So she looked in on the Fisher girl. She did the week's work. She wrote her ledger.

And on the fourth night she came up to bed at half past nine, and lit the candle, and turned to the other bed to check the thing she had checked every night for nineteen days.

The quilt lay flat.

Rebecca stood in the middle of the room with the candle in her hand.

She did not immediately understand what she was looking at. That was the strange part: her mind offered her, for one full second, the explanation that she must have moved it herself and forgotten. Then the second passed.

She crossed the room and pulled the quilt back anyway, because a person has to, and there was the mattress, gray and bare and slightly dented in the middle where

nine years of nothing had pressed it, and there was no muslin bundle on it and none under it and none anywhere in the bed at all.

She checked the whole room. She was aware of doing it stupidly (the drawer, the chest, under her own bed, the windowsill) and she did it anyway, twice, with the candle guttering.

Then she sat down on the edge of her own bed with her hands in her lap.

The notebook was gone. The silver clip was gone.

Nine and a half months of her sister's handwriting.

There are no locks in an Amish house.

Rebecca had never once thought about that in twenty-eight years. It was not a rule and it was not a hardship; it was simply a fact of the architecture, like the absence of a switch on the wall. Doors had latches. The front door had a bolt that was thrown at night against the weather and nothing else. Bedrooms did not lock, because what would a bedroom lock be for?

She sat in the dark and understood the shape of her own house for the first time.

Anyone. Any hour. Her mother, obviously. Her mother, who had known about the loose board since Rebecca was fifteen and who had had four days and a great deal of reason. But not only her mother. The door at the bottom of the stairs was never bolted before nine. The kitchen door stood unlocked from four in the morning when the milking started. In the last four days there had been in this house: her mother; Naomi Esh, twice, about a poultice; the Fisher boy with eggs; Enos Lapp, who had come to say thank you again about Katie in the awkward way of a man who could not stop saying it; and Sadie Beiler with a jar of pickled beets, who had gone up to use the necessary and had been gone, Rebecca now recalled, rather a long time.

Any of them. Any of them at all, and not one of them would have had to do anything more furtive than climb a staircase in a house where climbing the staircase is not a thing anybody notices.

She had hidden it in the one place nobody would put a hand.

Which meant that whoever had taken it had known exactly where to put their hand.

She did not go down and wake her mother.

She thought about it for perhaps an hour, lying on top of the covers with her boots still on, and what stopped her was not tact and not fear. It was that she could not decide what she would do if her mother said *yes*.

If Miriam Yoder sat up in bed and said *I took it, and I burned it, and I'd do it again*: what then? Rebecca could not leave. She could not report her mother to anybody; there was nobody to report her to. She could not stop loving her, having tried that for four days already with no success whatever.

So she lay in the dark and did the only thing that was actually available to her, which was to think.

And thinking, she found the small hard fact at the bottom of it, and held onto it like a rail.

I copied it.

Eleven pages, in her own hand, in her own work ledger, at half past five in the morning with her fingers going numb, because of a thought that had come to her at three o'clock and would not let her sleep. *The notebook can be taken.*

The ledger was not in the house.

The ledger went where she went. It was in her midwife's bag, which was on the hook inside the kitchen door, which was where it had been every night for nine years, because a bag that is not by the door is a bag you cannot pick up at two in the morning.

She got up, went down the stairs in her stockings past her mother's door, took the bag off the hook, and brought it back up.

She sat on the floor with her back against the bed and the candle on the boards and turned past the weights and the dates and the names of eleven years of babies, and there it was, in the pages after the Lapp girl: *11/2, W.G. 40*, in Rebecca Yoder's small even hand.

She put her forehead down on the open book and stayed like that for a while.

In the morning she did three things before breakfast.

The first was to go out to the buggy shed with a pencil and copy the eleven pages again, onto the flyleaf and endpapers of a battered Bible that lived in the shed for reading in the noon rest, a book nobody would ever pick up and nobody would ever burn.

The second was to write out a third copy on a folded sheet of paper, which she put in the toe of her spare boot in the trunk in the hall.

The third was harder, and she stood in the cold for ten minutes before she did it.

She went in, put on her coat, harnessed the horse, and drove to the phone shanty at the end of the Millers' lane (the one the district kept for calling the vet and the ambulance and the driver) and took a card out of her apron pocket, and dialed the number written on the back.

It rang four times.

"Cruz."

"It's Rebecca Yoder."

There was a pause and the sound of a chair.

"Go ahead."

"You told me to make copies and keep one out of my house." Rebecca watched her own breath fog the little window of the shanty. "The notebook was taken from my room last night."

"Are you all right?"

It was not the question she had expected, and it landed somewhere she was not braced for.

"Yes."

"Was anything else taken?"

"A hair clip. Silver, with blue stones — it was hers. It was the only other thing in the bundle."

"Doors forced? Windows?"

"There are no locks," said Rebecca. "There's nothing to force. That's what I'm telling you. Anyone who's been in my kitchen in four days could have walked up those stairs."

Cruz was quiet for a second.

"How many people is that?"

"Six. Seven with my mother."

"And you've got a copy."

"I've got three. One's in a Bible in a shed and one's in a boot."

"*Good*," said Marla Cruz, with real feeling. "Ms. Yoder, listen to me. Do not tell anybody that. Not one person, not your mother, not Beiler, not anybody. Whoever took that book is currently satisfied. That is the safest condition for you to be in and I would like to keep you in it."

Rebecca leaned her head against the cold wood of the shanty.

"They'll have burned it by now."

"Probably."

"Then it's gone. The only thing in the world in her handwriting — "

"It's not gone," said Cruz. "It's copied, in the hand of a woman who has kept contemporaneous professional records for nine years and can testify to when and where she made the copy. That's not nothing. That's a great deal more than most people bring me."

"It's not her writing."

There was a pause on the line.

"No," Cruz said. "It isn't. I'm sorry. That's a separate thing and I'm not going to pretend it isn't."

Rebecca stood in the shanty with the receiver against her ear and let herself have about four seconds of it, and then put it away.

"There's something else," she said. "The bishop came to my mother's house."

"And?"

"And a man confessed something to him in the spring after Sarah died, and was forgiven, and he won't say who." Rebecca closed her eyes. "But he told me one thing without meaning to. He said the man did not confess to killing anybody."

Marla Cruz was silent for long enough that Rebecca checked the line was still open.

"Ms. Yoder," the detective said at last, "I want you to think very carefully about something, and I want you to think about it before you talk to anyone else in that district. There's a version of this where a man confessed to stealing wages and nothing more, and your sister's death is exactly what the file says it is, and I need you to be able to survive that version being true."

"I know."

"Do you?"

"I've lived in that version for nine years," said Rebecca. "It's the other one I've only had for a month."

What Miriam Yoder Had Been Carrying

It came out on a Sunday, which was not a church Sunday, in the long empty afternoon of the off week when Amish houses are quiet in a way that other houses never are.

Rebecca had spent three days not asking.

She had decided that she would ask on the Monday, in the daylight, at the wash, on her feet. And then her mother came into the front room at two o'clock in the afternoon with her hands still wet from something and said, without any preamble at all:

"It was me."

Rebecca put down the mending.

"You took it."

"I took it on Wednesday night while you were at the Fishers'." Miriam stood in the middle of the room with her arms at her sides. "I'd have taken it a week before if I'd known where it was. It was in her bed, Rebecca. You put it in *her bed*."

"I did."

"You thought I'd not look there."

"I thought nobody would."

"Nine years," said Miriam Yoder, "I've made that bed every spring and aired that quilt every spring and put it back. Every year. In April. Who did you think was doing it?"

Rebecca sat with that.

It had never once occurred to her. The quilt was folded, and then it was not folded, and then it was folded again, and she had lived beside it for nine years without ever asking whose hands.

"Where is it?" she said.

"Burned."

"*Mamm.*"

"Wednesday night. In the kitchen stove, and I stood and watched it go, and I'll not say I'm sorry because I'm not." Her mother's chin came up. "The clip's in the creek below the Millers' bridge. I threw it off the rail on Thursday morning and I heard it go in."

Rebecca stood up.

She was aware of a very great anger arriving from somewhere a long way off, and of it being, when it got there, oddly cold, and not entirely about the notebook.

"That was hers."

"I know what it was."

"It was the only — " Rebecca's voice cracked on it and she made it stop. "There is nothing left of her in this house. There's a bed you air in April and a hymnbook with her name in it and that was the last thing in the world in her own hand, and you put it in a stove."

"Yes," said Miriam.

"*Why?*"

And her mother said: "Because I have read it."

The room went absolutely still.

"You've read it," Rebecca said.

"In the March after she died." Miriam sat down, suddenly, in the chair by the window, as though her legs had decided the matter for her. "Sadie Beiler's mother-in-law cleared the sewing room and I could not do it and she did it, and she brought me a box before she took the rest away, and she said, *Miriam, there's things here I'll not put on a fire without you seeing them*. And I sat in that sewing room with the door shut and I read every page of that book."

"You told me everything was burned."

"I told you everything was burned."

"You let me believe — for nine years — "

"Yes," said Miriam Yoder. "I did that."

Rebecca sat down slowly on the edge of the settee.

"Then why did the box come out of the Lapps' attic? If you had it — "

"Because I couldn't do it either." Her mother's hands twisted in her lap. "I read it and I understood about half of it, and I sat there for two hours, and then I put the lid on and I gave it back to Sadie's mother-in-law and I said, *take it away, I don't care where, only take it out of this house*. And she took it and she couldn't put it on the fire any more than I could, and she put it in her attic, and then she died. That's the whole of it. Two women, neither of them able to burn a dead girl's handwriting, and nine years of it sitting over the Lapps' cows."

"But you burned it on Wednesday."

"I've had nine years of practice," said her mother.

"Tell me what you understood," Rebecca said.

"I understood there was money that wasn't right. I understood there was a man's initials on every page." Miriam looked at the window. "And I understood that my daughter had been writing it down for the best part of a year and had not said one word to her mother, and I have never in my life felt anything like what I felt sitting in that room."

"Did you tell anyone?"

"I told Amos."

"You told the bishop."

"I went to him in the April and I put it in front of him and I said, *what is this*." Her mother's voice had gone flat and fast, the way a person talks when they have said a thing to themselves ten thousand times and never once out loud. "And he read it. And he went white. And he asked me who else had seen it, and I said nobody, and he said — "

She stopped.

"What did he say?"

"He said, *Miriam, I will deal with this, and I am asking you to leave it with me, and I am asking you not to speak of it again as long as you live.*" Miriam Yoder's hands were shaking now. "And I said, *is it to do with Sarah?* And he said — "

Rebecca waited.

"He said: *Not in the way you fear.*"

The clock ticked. Somewhere out in the yard a dog barked twice and stopped.

"And you accepted that," said Rebecca.

"I did."

"*Mamm* — "

"I accepted it because I was fifty-five years old and I had buried a child in January and my husband was already sick though we didn't know it yet, and Amos Stoltzfus had stood at that grave with me, and he looked me in the face and told me it was not what I feared." Miriam's eyes were streaming and she was not doing anything about it. "You want to know what I did with the rest of it? I put it where I put her. Same place. Same door. And I shut it, and I have kept it shut for nine years, and it has taken everything I have."

"You could have told me."

"You were nineteen."

"I'm twenty-eight."

"Yes," said Miriam. "And I've watched you for a month, Rebecca. I've watched you stop eating and start lying to me about Katie Lapp and drive out to a stone pit and sit in a shed at eleven at night with a candle. And what I saw was not a woman getting to the bottom of a thing. What I saw was you going the same way she went."

Rebecca went cold.

"What does that mean?"

"It means she was the same." Her mother's voice broke completely then, and she put both hands over her face and said, from behind them: "She was exactly the same. Quiet at supper and busy all day and something behind her eyes she wouldn't say, for months, and I did *nothing*, I thought it was a boy, I thought she was seventeen — and then a trooper came to my front room with his hat on his knee. And now I've got you doing it in the same kitchen."

She sat there with her hands over her face.

Rebecca crossed the room, knelt down beside the chair, and took her mother's wrists, and pulled her hands away, and held on to them.

"I'm not going to a quarry," she said.

"You don't know where you're going. She didn't."

"*Mamm.* Look at me." Rebecca waited until she did. "I'm not doing it alone. That's the difference. She was seventeen and she had nobody and she wrote it in a recipe book. I've a detective who knows what I have, and Daniel, and three copies of that book in three places, and one of them is not in this house."

Miriam Yoder went very still.

"Three copies," she said.

"Three."

Something went across her mother's face, a great many things at once, and Rebecca watched them go, and could not name most of them. Grief. Anger. And underneath, unmistakably, in a woman who had just admitted to burning her daughter's handwriting in a stove:

Relief.

"Then it wasn't for nothing," Miriam said.

"What wasn't?"

But her mother had already turned her hands over and taken hold of Rebecca's, hard, the way she had not done since the graveside, and she said:

"Ask me about the fourteenth of August."

Rebecca's breath stopped.

"What?"

"You've been asking about the seventeenth. That's the day the book stops." Miriam's grip tightened. "Ask me about the fourteenth. Three days before. Because that was the day your sister came into the kitchen at four in the afternoon with her sleeve torn and her hair down on one side, and told me she'd fallen off the back of the Zooks' wagon."

"She never — that's not in — "

"It's not in anything," said Miriam Yoder. "There was nobody in the kitchen but me. And I asked her twice, and she said it twice, and I let her go up and change her dress. And three days later she stopped writing in that book, and she stopped going on Thursdays, and I never thought about it again until I read those pages in March."

Rosa

Reading was an hour and ten minutes in a hired car, and Rebecca paid for it out of the money she kept in a tin for the vet.

Marla Cruz had found the address in four minutes and had then spent eleven arguing about whether Rebecca should have it.

"If I go, it's a police officer at her door about a thing that happened nine years ago," she had said on the phone. "If you go, it's a woman."

"And if she doesn't want to see me?"

"Then she doesn't, and you come home, and that's the end of it." A pause. "Ms. Yoder. If she tells you something — anything — you tell me before you tell another living soul. Not because I'll act on it. Because you'll need somebody to have heard it besides you."

Rosa Mendez Herrera lived in a row house with a green door and a plastic tricycle on the step, and she opened the door with a dish towel in her hand and a child of about four attached to her leg.

She was twenty-eight. Rebecca had done that arithmetic in the car and had found it doing something to her that she had not expected, and had had to look out of the window for a while.

Twenty-eight. The same as me. Nineteen, that summer, and Sarah was seventeen.

"You're the one my father called about," Rosa said.

"I am. Rebecca Yoder."

Rosa looked at the *kapp*, and at the plain coat, and something complicated happened in her face.

"He said you'd come," she said. "He said, *she'll come whatever I say, so I'm telling you first.*" She stood back from the door. "Come in. Don't mind the house."

The kitchen was small and warm and smelled of coffee. The child was dispatched to the front room with a tablet. Rosa put a cup in front of Rebecca and sat down across the table and did not touch her own.

"I remember her," she said. "Sarah. She sold pies and she couldn't say *jueves* to save her life."

"That's what your father says."

"My father says very little, so when he says a thing you can build a house on it." Rosa turned her cup around. "He told me what you have. The book. The numbers."

"It's been taken. I've copies."

"Good." Rosa nodded slowly. "Good. Then I'll say it once, and I'll not say it again after today, because I have said it exactly twice in nine years and both times it cost me a week."

Rebecca put her hands in her lap.

"I worked the office that summer," Rosa said. "Two days a week. I typed the tickets and did the scale sheets, and I was nineteen and I thought I was very clever because I was the only one of us who worked inside."

She said it evenly.

"He was fine for a month. He was — he is a friendly man. That's the thing people won't understand, and you may as well know I've given up trying to make them. He was friendly, and then he was friendly in a way that made me keep the desk between us, and then in August he came in on a Thursday afternoon when everybody was out at the face, and he put his hand on the back of my neck."

The clock over the stove.

"I got out," Rosa said. "That's the whole of it. I got out of the office and I went to my father's truck and I sat in it until the shift ended and I never went back inside that building again. I did the summer out in the yard, weighing, in the sun, and my father asked me why and I said the office was boring."

"You didn't tell him."

"I was nineteen and he was fifty and we had no papers," said Rosa. "What was he going to do? Go in and hit a man? Then what? Then we're all gone by Friday and my brother's out of school."

"Rosa — "

"I'm not asking you to say anything about it." Rosa's voice was perfectly steady. "I've had nine years. I know what I did and I know why, and if I'm honest I'd probably do the same again, and that is a thing I have made my peace with in a way I don't expect anybody else to."

Rebecca reached into her bag.

"I want to show you something," she said, "and I want to say first that I'm sorry to bring it into your house."

She put down, on the kitchen table, the folded sheet of paper on which she had drawn it, because the clip itself was in a creek below the Millers' bridge, and Rebecca had spent an hour with a pencil getting the scrollwork right.

Rosa Mendez looked at the drawing.

Then she got up and went to the sink and stood with her back to the room and her hands on the edge of it.

"Where did you get that," she said.

"It was in my sister's things. Wrapped in cloth, at the bottom of a box, under a handkerchief. It's been in an attic for nine years."

"That's mine."

"Your father said your grandmother gave it to you."

"For my fifteenth." Rosa did not turn around. "I lost it that August. I thought — I always thought it came off in the yard, in the gravel, and I looked for a week. I told myself somebody's boot pushed it under the stone."

"It didn't come off in the yard," Rebecca said.

"No," said Rosa. "It came off in the office."

She came back to the table after a while and sat down, and this time she picked up her coffee.

"The fourteenth of August," Rebecca said. "Do you remember what day of the week that was?"

"I don't."

"It was a Monday." Rebecca had checked it three times against the almanac, and once more in the county library, because she had not trusted herself. "My sister came home that afternoon with her sleeve torn and her hair down, and told my mother she'd fallen off a wagon. And three days later she stopped writing in that book, and arranged never to be at the market stand on a Thursday again, and asked for every dollar she was owed in her hand that night."

Rosa was very still.

"She went in there," she said.

"I think she went in there."

"Why would she — " Rosa stopped, and her face changed, and Rebecca watched her arrive at it. "Because I stopped going inside."

"What?"

"I went out to the yard in the first week of August." Rosa put her cup down with a small click. "And she'd have seen it. She stood at that stand four hundred yards up the road with nothing to do but watch, and she knew what days I worked, and one week I'm at the office window and the next week I'm out on the scale in a hat."

"Would she have known why?"

"No." Rosa said it hard. "How could she. She was seventeen and Amish and I never spoke to her about anything but pie."

"Then why go in?"

And Rosa Mendez looked across the table at Rebecca Yoder and said, slowly, like a woman turning something over that she had never been able to hold before:

"Because she had a list of five men being robbed and she'd stopped being able to ask the men about it, because they'd stopped coming down for the pies in July. And the only other person who worked there and might talk to her was the girl in the office. And then the girl in the office wasn't in the office any more."

The child said something in the front room, and neither of them heard it.

"She came to find me," Rosa said.

They sat with it.

"She'd have gone up the lane on a Monday afternoon," Rebecca said at last. "In August. When the men were out at the face."

"And I wasn't there."

"No."

"And he was."

"Yes."

Rosa put both hands flat on the table, and her voice, when it came, was not steady any more.

"Then she went in for me," she said. "She went in that door for a girl she'd sold pie to."

"You don't know that."

"I know what's in that office," said Rosa Mendez, "and I know what he does when the yard's empty, and I know that my clip was on that floor since the Thursday before, and she came out with it in her hand. What else would that be? Tell me what else that would be."

Rebecca had no answer.

"And then she lived five more months," Rosa said, "and told nobody, and neither did I."

"You were nineteen."

"So was she, near enough." Rosa wiped her face with the back of her wrist, once, exactly the way her father had. "I'm sorry. I'm sorry, I've not done this in a long time."

"You've nothing to be sorry for."

"I've one thing," said Rosa. "And I'll tell you it and then I'd like you to go, and I mean that kindly."

"Tell me."

"After she died — in the spring, when everybody was still talking about the Amish girl at the quarry — I nearly went to the police." Rosa looked at the table. "I got as far as the parking lot. I sat there forty minutes. And then I thought: they will ask me why I did not report it in August. And I will have to say, *because I had no papers and I was afraid*. And they will hear *because it did not happen*."

She looked up.

"And I drove home," said Rosa. "And I have known ever since that I might have been able to say something, and I did not, and there is no bottom to that. So when you ask me now — and you're going to ask me now — whether I will stand up and say it, I want you to understand that I have already lived nine years inside the answer."

Rebecca said nothing at all.

"Ask me," said Rosa.

"No," said Rebecca.

Rosa blinked.

"No?"

"I came here for what happened to my sister, and you've given me that, and it's more than I had any right to." Rebecca stood and picked up her bag. "I'll not sit at your kitchen table and ask you to pay for it. If you decide to, you'll know where I am, and I'll be glad, and if you don't I'll never once think worse of you."

Rosa Mendez stood up too.

She came around the table and she did something that no one in Willow Creek had done in nine years, which was to put her arms around Rebecca Yoder and hold on.

"Her name was Sarah," she said, into Rebecca's shoulder.

"Yes."

"Nobody in my house has said it out loud since the year it happened. My father won't. He goes quiet." Rosa let go and stepped back and looked at her, dry-eyed and fierce. "Give me until my brother's wife has the baby."

"April."

"April," said Rosa. "And then come back and ask me properly."

The Twenty Minutes

"I want to ask you the question again," Rebecca said, "and I want to ask it better."

They were in the woodshed. The corner cupboard had doors on it now, and a back, and Daniel had got as far as the fitting of the shelves, which he was doing badly on purpose because finishing it would leave him with nothing.

"Ask."

"Nine years everybody's asked you *where were you*." She sat down on the sawhorse. "I don't want that. I want to know what you *saw*. Between ten past nine and half past nine, on the north side of that quarry, in the dark. Not where you were. What was in front of your eyes."

Daniel put the chisel down.

"That's a different question," he said slowly.

"I know it is."

"Nobody's ever — " He stopped. He looked at the wall for a while. "The trooper asked me nine or ten times where I was and could anybody confirm it, and I said the same thing every time and every time it got worse, and after a while I stopped being able to think about that twenty minutes as anything except the thing I couldn't prove."

"So think about it as twenty minutes."

He was quiet for a long moment.

"There was a vehicle," he said.

Rebecca did not move.

"On the quarry road," Daniel said. "Pulled off, up past the second bend where the pines come down, sitting on the verge with the lights off. I came round the

north side and I was up above it on the bank and I looked down at it." His brow furrowed with the effort of it. "That's why I went that way. That's the thing I could never get hold of — I've told myself for nine years I was walking in a temper, and I *was* in a temper, but I went round the north side because I saw a truck on the road with no lights and I was seventeen and I wanted to know whose it was."

"Whose was it?"

"I never got close enough. I came down the bank and it was gone." He shook his head. "That's all. It was there and then it wasn't, and I thought — I remember exactly what I thought, and I can hear myself thinking it — I thought *somebody's out with a girl*, and I was seventeen and it seemed hilarious, and I walked to the crossroads and Emma passed me and I went home."

"You never told the trooper."

"Rebecca, it wasn't *anything*." He said it with a kind of despair. "It was a truck on a road. There are trucks on roads. If I'd said to that man *I saw a vehicle and I can't describe it and I never got near it* — from me, of all people, the boy who couldn't say where he was — do you know what that becomes? That becomes a story I made up on the spot."

She sat with it.

He was right. That was the miserable part: he was entirely right. At seventeen, cornered, having already failed to account for himself, the single most dangerous thing Daniel Beiler could have done was offer an unverifiable detail.

"What kind of truck?"

"A pickup. Dark. Not new."

"Colour?"

"It was January and it was ten at night and there was no moon."

"Anything on it? Writing? A rack?"

Daniel opened his mouth to say no.

Then he shut it again.

He stood absolutely still in the middle of the woodshed with a chisel in his hand and a look on his face that Rebecca had never seen on anybody, and she understood that she was watching a man go somewhere he had not been allowed to go in nine years.

"There was a light bar," he said. "Not on. A bar across the top of the cab with lamps on it. And —"

He put the chisel down very carefully, as though it might go off.

"And the tailgate was dropped," he said. "It was sitting there with the tailgate down. That's why I could see there was nothing in the bed. I remember looking at an empty bed and thinking, *well, he's not been for wood*."

Rebecca drove to the phone shanty in the dark.

"Cruz."

"A dark pickup, not new, light bar on the cab, tailgate down, parked with its lights off on the quarry road above the second bend, some time between ten past nine and half past nine on the night of the sixteenth of January."

There was a silence on the line.

"Say that again."

She said it again.

"Who's your source?"

"Daniel Beiler."

"Ms. Yoder — " Cruz's voice changed. "Ms. Yoder, listen to me carefully. Nine years ago that man told the state police he was walking around a quarry in a bad mood and could not account for himself, and tonight he has produced a vehicle description. Do you understand how that reads?"

"It reads like he made it up," said Rebecca. "I know exactly how it reads. I'm telling you what he said and I'm telling you I believe him, and I know the difference between those two things."

"Why do you believe him?"

"Because I asked him a question nobody had ever asked him." Rebecca leaned her head against the wall of the shanty. "Nine years of *where were you*. Not one *what did you see*. He's not been able to look at that twenty minutes without seeing his own guilt in it. I gave him something else to look at and the road came back."

Cruz was quiet.

"That's actually not a bad answer," she said at last.

"It's the truth."

"They're occasionally the same thing." A pen clicked. "All right. Here's what a light bar means, and don't get excited, because it means less than you want it to. It means it's a work truck. Farm, contractor, tow, plow. In this county in January that's four thousand vehicles."

"And the tailgate?"

"The tailgate's interesting," Cruz admitted. "A man parked up in the dark with his tailgate down at half nine at night in January. That's not somebody meeting a girl. That's somebody who's put something in or taken something out."

"Or is about to."

"Or is about to," Cruz agreed. "Don't. Don't go there. That's a road with nothing at the end of it and you'll wear yourself out on it."

Rebecca watched her breath on the little window.

"There's something else," she said, and told her about Rosa.

She told it carefully and without ornament, the way Rosa had told it, and when she had finished Marla Cruz did not say anything for a long time.

"Where is she now?" the detective said finally.

"Reading. She's got children."

"And she said April."

"She said come back and ask me properly."

"Ms. Yoder." Cruz's voice had gone very level. "I need to say a hard thing and I need you to hear all of it before you answer."

"Go on."

"What that woman described is an assault. It has no statute problem — there's no time bar on it in this state, not for that. If she stands up, that is a live criminal complaint against Wilmer Graber in the year of our Lord today, entirely separate from wages, entirely separate from your sister." A breath. "And a man with a live complaint of that kind against him is a man whose life gets looked into. His books. His employment records. His property. Everything."

"You're saying she's the whole thing."

"I'm saying she is the **only** thing," said Cruz. "And I am also saying that she has already paid for this once, that she owes you nothing, and that if you push her before April I will personally never speak to you again."

"I told her I wouldn't ask."

"You told her you wouldn't ask **tonight**."

"I told her," said Rebecca, "that if she decided not to, I'd never once think worse of her, and I meant it, and I'll hold to it."

Marla Cruz let out a breath.

"Then you're a better woman than the last three complainants' families I've dealt with," she said. "Go home. It's nine o'clock and you're standing in a box in a field."

She did not go home directly.

She turned at the crossroads and drove the long way, out past the Hostetler place, and pulled up at the wire fence that the county had put across the entrance to the old quarry in the spring after her sister drowned.

She had not been there in nine years.

There was nothing to see. A fence, a gap in the pines, a track going down under old snow, and beyond it in the dark the flat sheet of the water with the ice on it, exactly as it was every January and would be every January after she was dead.

Rebecca sat in the buggy with the reins loose in her hands.

It was not the ice, she thought. *It was never the ice.*

And she found, sitting there in the cold with the horse shifting between the shafts, that she had stopped counting days some time in the last few weeks and had not noticed when.

The Man Who Came to Clear the Air

He came on a Tuesday, in the middle of the afternoon, in a dark pickup with a light bar on the cab.

Rebecca was in the barn.

She heard the engine come up the lane and thought it was the milk hauler, who was late; and then it stopped in the yard and did not have the milk hauler's diesel rattle, and she came out of the stall with a fork in her hand and saw the truck standing in front of her mother's house, and Wilmer Graber getting down out of it in his canvas coat.

Her whole body understood before she did. She felt it go through her, the drop, the cold in the hands, and she stood in the barn doorway and made herself finish the breath she was on.

A light bar on the cab. Four thousand vehicles in this county.

"Miss Yoder!" He raised a hand. He was smiling. "I hoped it'd be you."

"I'll not come in," he said. "I've boots on and I'm not stopping."

They stood in the barn's wide doorway, which was, Rebecca noticed with the cold clear part of her mind, in full view of the road, of the house, and of Naomi Esh's kitchen window a quarter mile off.

He had chosen it. Or he had not chosen it and it was simply where a man stands when he comes to a farm.

"I've been hearing things," Wilmer Graber said, "and I've decided I'd rather come and say my piece than have it go round the county in the usual way. My wife says I should have let it be. She's likely right; she generally is."

"What have you been hearing?"

"That you've been asking after my payroll." He said it easily, without any edge at all. "That you were at Barbara Zook's about her books, and out at Kinzers to see Efrain, and that you're carrying about some notion that I've been short-changing my men."

"Who told you that?"

"Now, Miss Yoder." He almost laughed. "In this county? Nobody told me. Everybody told me."

Rebecca set the fork against the doorframe, tines down, and kept her hands where he could see them, and did not answer.

"So here it is," said Graber. "There is a deduction. There has been for years. It's on the sheet and it's above board and I'll show it to you or to anybody who asks." He counted it off on his fingers, unhurried. "There's a fellow in Lancaster does the paperwork for the seasonal men — the I-9s, the tax numbers, the whole business. He charges me a fee per man per season. I pay it up front in March, and I take it back out of the weekly through the year, because if I asked those men for four hundred dollars in March not one of them could give it to me."

It was, Rebecca thought, an extremely good answer.

It was so good that she felt the ground move under her, because it accounted for everything. A deduction that started small and grew as the season went on and as more men came. A thing the men would not question because the explanation was true enough to be unanswerable.

"Fifteen dollars a week," she said. "For nine months. From five men."

"You've done the sums, then."

"I've done the sums."

"So have I," said Wilmer Graber. "That's what a fee looks like when you spread it over a year instead of taking it in a lump. It looks like robbery on a page and it looks like a kindness in March." He shrugged. "You're welcome to ring the man in Lancaster. I'll give you the number. I'd rather you did, honestly, than go on wondering."

"Would he tell me what he charges?"

"He'd tell you what he charges me. What I take back out is between me and my men, and there's not a court in this state would call it anything else." He put his hands in his coat pockets. "That's the whole of it. It's dull. Most things are."

She let the silence sit.

He did not fill it, which she noted. Nervous men fill silences. Wilmer Graber stood in a barn doorway in February with his hands in his pockets and waited, comfortably, like a man at a bus stop.

"You told me you didn't remember my sister," Rebecca said.

"I said I couldn't place her. There's a girl at that stand most — "

"You said, *which sister*."

"Did I?"

"You said, *my wife'd know, she buys the chow-chow*."

Wilmer Graber's expression did not change at all.

"Then I likely said it," he agreed. "It's the sort of thing I'd say. My memory's poor and my wife's is not."

"And now?"

"Now I've had a month to think about it, haven't I," he said, "on account of a young woman coming to my yard and then going round the county asking about my books. So yes, I've thought about it, and yes, I remember her better now than I did standing in my own gate with no warning."

"What do you remember?"

He looked out at the yard.

"I remember she came up the lane once," he said. "In the summer. Late in the summer. She'd have been sixteen, seventeen — she came up asking after the men, whether they wanted pies brought up, some such thing, because they'd stopped coming down for them." He shook his head slowly. "I told her the men bring their own dinners now and that was that. She was five minutes in the office. And she caught her sleeve on the latch going out — that door's got a hasp on it that's caught half the county — and tore it, and she was in a state about it, and I said send me the mending bill and she never did."

The barn was very quiet.

Rebecca stood absolutely still and heard, very clearly, in her mother's voice, from a chair by the window on a Sunday afternoon:

She came into the kitchen at four in the afternoon with her sleeve torn and her hair down on one side, and told me she'd fallen off the back of the Zooks' wagon.

She had not told him about the sleeve.

She had not told anybody about the sleeve. Her mother had told her four days ago in a room with the door shut, and Miriam Yoder had said *there was nobody in the kitchen but me*, and Sarah had told her mother a lie about a wagon and had gone upstairs and changed her dress and had never mentioned it again to a living soul in nine years of being dead.

There was one other person in the world who knew that Sarah Yoder had torn her sleeve on the fourteenth of August.

He was standing in front of her with his hands in his pockets, offering to pay for the mending.

Rebecca did not move and did not look away, and she understood, with a clarity that arrived from somewhere very far down, that the next thing she said was the most important sentence of her life.

She thought: *if I ask him now, he will know that I know.*

She thought: *he came here to find out how much I have. He is doing it right now. He has been doing it since he got out of the truck.*

And she thought, last and coldest: *he has just told me, and he does not know that he has, because he does not know that my mother finally spoke.*

"That was good of you," she said. "About the mending."

Wilmer Graber's face relaxed by some fraction so small that she would not have caught it if she had not been watching for it with everything she had.

"Well," he said. "It's a poor sort of man that tears a girl's dress and doesn't offer."

"It is."

"I'd have thought no more about it in my life, only you came asking." He took his hands out of his pockets, done. "Anyway. That's my piece said. Ring the man in Lancaster; I'll drop the number in at the mill for you. And Miss Yoder — "

"Yes?"

"I'd not have come," he said, "but a thing like this gets away from a person. Somebody says a word at a feed store and in a fortnight there's men won't take my stone." He put his cap on. "I've a business and a wife and twenty-six years in this county. That's all I'm minding."

"I understand."

"I thought you might." He nodded at the barn, at the yard, at the whole of it. "You've a place here too."

He got into the truck and turned it in the yard and went down the lane, and Rebecca Yoder stood in the doorway and watched a dark pickup with a light bar on the cab go out onto the road, and did not move for a very long time.

Then she went into the house, past her mother at the stove, up the stairs, and sat on the edge of her bed and wrote it all down, every word of it, in order, in her work ledger, with the date and the hour at the top of the page, while her hands were still steady enough to do it.

At the bottom she wrote:

He said sleeve. Nobody told him. Mamm told me on Sunday, in the front room, door shut. Sarah told Mamm a wagon.

Then she went down to the phone shanty.

What It Would Cost

The bishop asked for the meeting, and Rebecca agreed to it, and it was held in the front room of her mother's house on a Thursday evening in the last week of February with four people present.

Amos Stoltzfus. Miriam. Rebecca.

And, because Rebecca had said she would not sit in a room and be talked to alone and the bishop had not argued, Daniel Beiler, sitting on the hard chair by the door with his hat on his knee like a man at a hearing.

"I'll say it plainly," said the bishop. "There's talk. It's got as far as the Gap district and I had Bishop Riehl on the phone from the mill about it, which has not happened in nineteen years. So we'll have it out here, tonight, among ourselves, and then I'll ask you for a decision."

"Whose decision?" said Rebecca.

"Yours."

He laid it out fairly. She granted him that afterward, when she could grant him anything at all: Amos Stoltzfus did not cheat, and he did not pretend, and he put the whole of it on the table including the parts that cost him.

"Here is what I did," he said. "In the April after your sister died, your mother brought me a book. I read it and I understood it. I went to Wilmer Graber and I put it to him. He confessed to me that he had been taking money from his men that was not his to take, and he wept, and he said it had got away from him a little at a time, and I believed him — I believed that part, and I believe it still. He made restitution."

"He *what*?"

"He paid it back." The bishop's mouth was a line. "Not to the men. He couldn't — half of them were gone by the April and he'd no names for the rest. He paid it to me, and I put it into the district's fund for hardship, and it went out over three years to families that needed it, and it is all written in the book at the mill and you may see it whenever you like."

The room was silent.

"And that's what forgiveness was," said Rebecca.

"That is what it was."

"And Sarah?"

"I asked him." Amos Stoltzfus looked at his hands. "I asked him directly, in that shop, whether he had had any part in what happened at the quarry, and he said no, and he swore it, and I looked at him and I believed him." He raised his eyes. "That is the whole of my sin, Rebecca, and I have known it was a sin for nine years. I did not believe him because the evidence was good. I believed him because if it were not true then I would have had to take a thing to the *Englisch* law that would have broken this district in half — and I did not want that, and a man who does not want a thing will find reasons."

"You could have gone to the police in the April."

"Yes."

"And they'd have had a man to look at, and a book in her own hand, and it nine weeks old instead of nine years."

"Yes," said the bishop.

Nobody said anything for a while.

"Well," he said at last. "There it is. Now the decision."

"You know what I have," Rebecca said.

"Daniel's told me what you have, at your asking, and I'm glad it came that way." The bishop nodded at him. "You have a copy in your own hand of a book that is burned. You have Barbara Zook's ledger showing the girl changed her day. You have what your mother saw on the fourteenth of August. And you have a man who came to this yard and mentioned a torn sleeve that nobody had told him about."

"That's it."

"And what will you do with it?"

"I'll give it to Detective Cruz," said Rebecca, "and I'll ask her to do what she thinks right."

Amos Stoltzfus sat back.

"Then let me tell you what that will cost," he said, "not to stop you. To make sure you're paying it with your eyes open, which is the only thing I've any business doing at this stage."

"Go on."

"Wilmer Graber will be looked into. That will take months and it may come to nothing at all, because a torn sleeve is not evidence and a burned book is not evidence and what your mother heard is not evidence." He held up a hand. "It may come to something. I'm not saying it won't. I'm saying the first year of it will be all cost and no result, and you'll be living in that year here, in this district, with these people."

"I know."

"You do not know. Let me say it and then you may tell me you know." He leaned forward. "The moment that woman opens a file, every family in Willow Creek is in it. She'll want to know who was at the quarry. She'll interview Emma Stoltzfus, who has five children and a husband in Gap. She'll want Barbara Zook's ledgers and Barbara Zook is seventy-one. She'll come to this house with a recorder and she'll ask your mother to say out loud, on a machine, in a room, what her daughter looked like on the fourteenth of August."

Miriam Yoder made a small sound.

"And she will ask Daniel Beiler," said the bishop, "to explain, on the record, why he did not mention a vehicle in the year two thousand and seventeen."

Daniel did not move.

"He'll be looked at again," Amos went on. "Properly, this time — not by a trooper doing a form, but by a detective with a case. Nine years after this district decided in its heart he'd done something and then let him leave rather than say so. He has asked to come back and be baptized. If this goes forward he will be, for a year or more, the man from the quarry all over again."

"That's mine to answer," said Daniel.

"It is. Answer it."

Daniel Beiler turned his hat over once on his knee.

"I've been the man from the quarry for nine years," he said. "I've been it in Philadelphia, where nobody knew there was a quarry. I'd rather be it here for a year with a reason than be it everywhere forever for nothing."

The bishop looked at him for a long moment.

"That's a better answer than I'd have given at your age," he said.

"And the district?" Rebecca asked.

"The district will split," said Amos Stoltzfus. "That's not a threat. I've no power to make it and no wish to. It's simply what will happen." He counted it out, unhappily, like a man doing accounts he has already done. "There will be families who say: the girl is right, the man stole, and the law is the law. There will be more who say: it is nine years past, and Amos gave forgiveness, and if we let this be pulled up now then nothing that was ever settled is settled. And there will be some who say the thing that will hurt you most."

"Which is?"

"That you are doing it for yourself." He said it gently. "That it is grief and pride wearing the clothes of justice, and that you'd not have gone near it if it had been anybody's sister but your own."

Rebecca sat with her hands in her lap.

"Is that what you think?" she said.

"No," said the bishop. "I think you'd have let it lie for nine years if a box hadn't come out of an attic, same as the rest of us, and that when it came you did the harder thing. But you asked me what they'll say, and that's what some of them will say, and you'll hear it at church, and you will not be able to answer it, because the true answer is *yes, and also no*, and there's no saying that in a barn on a Sunday."

It was her mother who ended it.

Miriam Yoder had not spoken since the beginning. She sat by the window with her hands folded, and when she finally spoke everybody in the room turned, because it had been that kind of nine years.

"Amos," she said. "When you came to my house in the April, and I gave you that book, what did I say to you?"

The bishop's face changed.

"Miriam — "

"What did I say to you?"

He was quiet for a moment.

"You said," he answered, "*if this is what I think it is, I want it stopped.*"

"And you said you'd deal with it."

"I did."

"And I let you." Miriam's voice was perfectly steady. "Because I was tired, and because you're the bishop, and because I could not have stood one more thing. And I have carried it for nine years and it has taken the whole of me, and I have watched it start to take my second daughter, and I will not sit in this room and let it be called forgiveness."

She looked at Rebecca.

"Take it to the woman," she said. "And I'll sit in front of her machine and say what I saw."

"*Mamm* — "

"I'll say it once and I'll say it plain and then I'll not say it again," said Miriam Yoder. "That's the same thing your sister did, and I've spent nine years thinking she was foolish for it, and I was wrong. She wasn't foolish. She was just alone."

The room was very still.

Amos Stoltzfus put his hands on his knees and stood up, slowly, an old man in a front room.

"Then that's the decision," he said, "and it's not mine, and I'll not stand against it." He put his hat on. "Rebecca. When this goes badly — and some of it will go badly, whatever else happens — you'll find I'm still your bishop, and this house is still in my district, and I'll come when I'm called."

"I know."

"Yes." He paused at the door. "For what it's worth, and it's worth very little at this hour: I should have gone to the law in the April, and I have known it every day since, and I would give a great deal to have that year back."

He went out.

They heard the horse in the yard, and then the lane, and then nothing.

And Rebecca Yoder sat in her mother's front room with Daniel Beiler by the door and her mother by the window and understood that whatever happened after this, she was not carrying it by herself any more.

The Tenth of April

She handed it over on the last day of February, in the front room, with her mother sitting beside her on the settee.

Marla Cruz had come alone, in her own car, and had brought a folder and a recorder and a form Rebecca had to sign, and the whole business took eleven minutes and was one of the strangest experiences of Rebecca's life, because she had carried the thing for six weeks and had expected the handing over to feel like something, and it felt like filling in a delivery note.

She put on the table: her work ledger, open at the pages after the Lapp baby's weight, with eleven pages of dates and initials copied in her own hand. The folded sheet from the toe of her boot. The Bible from the shed with its flyleaf covered in pencil.

"Three copies," said Cruz. "You weren't joking."

"You told me to."

"People are told a great many things." The detective turned the ledger around and looked at the copied pages for a while without saying anything. Then she looked at the pages before them, and the pages after: the births, the weights, the times, nine years of a woman's small even handwriting running unbroken through the same book. "Ms. Yoder, do you understand what this is?"

"It's a copy. You said the copy was worth less."

"I said the handwriting was gone and I was sorry about it, and that's still true." Cruz tapped the page. "But this is a contemporaneous record kept by a professional in the ordinary course of her work, and the copy sits inside it, between a birth on the fourth and a birth on the ninth, in the same ink, in the same hand, in a book that has never been out of your possession. Nobody made that later. Nobody could."

She sat back. "A defense lawyer will still go at it. But he'll have to go at *you*, on a stand, in front of a jury, and he'll be attacking a midwife's record-keeping. I've seen worse positions."

Rebecca had not thought of it that way at all.

"And this," said Cruz, picking up the Bible, "is the strangest exhibit I have ever been handed, and I have been handed a frozen chicken."

Miriam Yoder made a sound that was almost a laugh.

Then Cruz set the recorder in the middle of the table and said, "Mrs. Yoder. Whenever you're ready, and you can stop at any point, and if you want to stop and not start again that's your right and I'll pack up and go."

Miriam looked at the little black thing for a moment.

"It's smaller than I thought," she said.

"They usually are."

Rebecca's mother folded her hands in her lap, and looked at a point on the wall about four feet above the recorder, and said, in a completely steady voice:

"My name is Miriam Yoder. On the fourteenth of August in the year my daughter Sarah was seventeen, she came into my kitchen at about four in the afternoon with the left sleeve of her dress torn at the shoulder and her hair down on one side, and she told me she had fallen off the back of the Zooks' wagon."

She spoke for nineteen minutes.

She did not cry, and she did not stop, and she did not once look at Rebecca. When she had finished she said, "That's all of it," and Cruz said, "Thank you," and turned the recorder off, and Miriam stood up and went into the kitchen and began, immediately and loudly, to do something with pans.

Cruz let her go.

"Nineteen minutes," she said quietly, to Rebecca. "In eighteen years I have taken perhaps four statements that clean. She's been rehearsing that in her head since 2017."

"She never said a word of it."

"No," said Marla Cruz. "That's usually when they rehearse it most."

After that, nothing happened, and it did not happen the way Rebecca had imagined it, because nothing does.

There was no moment. That was the thing nobody tells you about the law: it does not arrive. It accumulates.

February became March. Marla Cruz opened a file, and then had it taken off her and given to a unit in Lancaster that dealt with labor cases, and then got it back, partly, because the labor unit did not want the 2017 file attached to it and Cruz would not let the 2017 file be unattached. There were two interviews at the Yoder house, both of them in the kitchen, both of them with a small black recorder on the table that Miriam Yoder looked at once and then ignored entirely.

Barbara Zook gave up thirty-four years of ledgers in a cardboard box and said, when the young officer thanked her, "You'll bring them back. I've told my son they're not to be burned."

Emma Stoltzfus cried in her own front room and said she had always known there was something and had never once said so, and gave a statement that added, in the end, almost nothing.

Daniel Beiler sat for four hours in a county building in Lancaster and explained, nine years late, why a seventeen-year-old had not mentioned a pickup truck. He came home grey in the face and did not speak for a day and a half, and then went back out to the woodshed and finished the corner cupboard.

Nothing happened.

That was March.

In the first week of April, Efrain Mendez's daughter-in-law had a girl, and Rebecca did not go and did not write and did not send word, because she had said she would not and because she had discovered in herself a stubbornness about that particular promise that surprised her.

On the tenth of April, Rosa Mendez Herrera drove to Lancaster and made a statement that took five hours.

Rebecca learned about it two days later, from Cruz, on the phone in the shanty at the end of the Millers' lane.

"She asked me to tell you three things," Cruz said. "One: she did it. Two: she does not want to be thanked and she does not want a visit. Three — " a pause, and something in the detective's voice that Rebecca had not heard before " — three, she said: *tell her I said the name out loud.*"

Rebecca stood in the box in the field with her hand over her mouth.

"Ms. Yoder?"

"I'm here."

"There's more and it's better and I need you to sit down, except you're standing in a shanty, so hold onto something."

"Go on."

"With a complaint of that nature we can look at the business properly. We went in with a warrant on Tuesday for payroll and personnel." Cruz's voice was very controlled, which was how Rebecca knew. "Wilmer Graber does not keep a filing cabinet. He keeps everything. Twenty-six years of it, in a portable office, in boxes, because he's the sort of man who has never thrown out a piece of paper in his life."

"And?"

"And in a box marked 2016–2017 there is a ledger in his own hand," said Marla Cruz, "with a column for what was paid and a column for what was disbursed, exactly as your sister set it out, for every week of that season. Every single week. He wrote it down himself."

Rebecca leaned her forehead against the cold wood.

"He kept it."

"They always keep it. Eighteen years and I have never once understood why, and they always, always keep it." A breath. "It's not your sister's death, Ms. Yoder. I want to be very clear with you about that, today, before anybody else says anything to you. It's wage theft across two seasons and it's the assault and those are the charges. Nobody is charging anybody with what happened at that quarry and on today's evidence nobody is going to be."

"I know."

"Do you? Because in about four days somebody in your district is going to tell you that the man who killed your sister has been arrested, and that will not be true, and if you let yourself believe it you will be destroyed when the case comes out the way cases come out."

"Detective." Rebecca closed her eyes. "I have known since February that I would never get that. I stopped asking for it somewhere around the night my mother told me about the sleeve."

"Then what are you doing?"

Rebecca thought about it.

"He took nine hundred dollars a year off men who couldn't say anything," she said, "and he put his hand on a girl of nineteen, and my sister found out and it killed her one way or another, and for nine years the whole arrangement of the world was

that none of that had happened. That's what I wanted stopped. That it should go on not having happened."

There was a long silence on the line.

"He was arrested this morning," said Marla Cruz. "He's out already — it's not that sort of charge. But it's filed, and it's public, and it'll be in the *Intelligencer Journal* on Friday."

On the Thursday, Efrain Mendez came to Willow Creek.

He came in his son's truck and he did not get out of it. Rebecca saw it standing at the end of the lane from the kitchen window and went down in her apron with her sleeves still rolled, and he put the window down and did not turn the engine off.

"I have given a statement," he said.

Rebecca stood in the road with her hands wet.

"You didn't have to."

"No." He looked straight ahead through the windscreen. "My daughter did it on Tuesday and told me on Wednesday. She did not ask me first. She is twenty-eight years old and she did not ask me first, and I sat in my kitchen for one hour being angry, and then I understood that she had not asked me because she knew what I would say, and that she was right about what I would say, and that she went anyway."

His hands were on the wheel at ten and two, like a man taking a driving test.

"So on Wednesday night I could not sleep," he said, "and I thought: my daughter has said the thing out loud, and I am the one who taught her to be quiet, and she has done it anyway, and now I will be the man who let her stand there by herself?" He shook his head once. "No. So this morning I went and I said forty and twenty, and the names of the four others, and where two of them are now."

"Efrain — "

"It is not for you." He turned and looked at her for the first time, and there was nothing warm in it and nothing unkind either; it was simply true. "You understand? It is not for your sister and it is not for you. Nine years I did nothing and I could have done nothing for nine more. It is because my daughter did not ask me."

"I understand."

"Good." He faced forward again. "The lawyer says my papers are a separate matter and they will not touch it. I do not believe him entirely. But he wrote it down

and gave me his card, and there is a woman from an office in Lancaster who will come."

"Cruz?"

"The detective, yes. She is — " he searched for it " — she is not stupid. That is the most I will say about police."

Rebecca laughed, once, entirely without meaning to, and Efrain Mendez's mouth moved very slightly at one corner.

"The baby came," he said. "The tenth. A girl. Everyone is well."

"I'm glad."

"Rosa says you did not come and did not write."

"I said I wouldn't ask her before April. I thought if I came it would be asking, whatever I said."

Efrain Mendez was quiet for a moment.

"That is a small thing," he said, "and it is the reason she went on Tuesday. I will tell you that and then I will go, because I do not want to be sitting in this road when the man from the mill comes past."

He put the truck in gear.

"Your sister came out to the road," he said, "when we stopped buying the pies. Nobody else in nine years has kept a promise to my family. Two of you now. It is not many, but it is two."

It was in the **Intelligencer Journal** on Friday, and by Sunday it had gone through Willow Creek the way a fire goes through standing corn.

Church was at the Fishers'.

Rebecca went. Her mother went with her. She had spent the whole of Saturday deciding that she would go, and had got up on Sunday and put on her good dress and had not eaten anything.

What she had expected was silence.

What she got was worse and more complicated, and it took her most of the morning to understand it, because it came at her in pieces from forty directions.

Naomi Esh took her hand at the door and said, loudly, into the general hush, "You've done right, girl," and then, at her usual volume, "Somebody had to."

Sadie Beiler would not look at her.

Emma Stoltzfus's husband, whom Rebecca had known since they were both eight, walked past her twice without speaking and then came back the third time and

said, very fast and very quietly, "My wife's not slept in a fortnight. I hope you know what you've started," and walked off before she could answer.

Two of the Miller women came and sat with her at the meal, on purpose, one on either side, and talked about nothing at all for twenty minutes with the tenacity of women holding a line.

Old Jonas Beiler, who was eighty-six and had buried a wife and four children, stopped in front of her with his stick and said, "Your father would be ashamed," and then, before anybody could move: "Of *us*. Not of you. Of the rest of us, for the nine years." And went on to his seat.

And at the far end of the barn, four families sat together who had not sat together before, and did not come to the meal, and left early.

The bishop preached on Matthew eighteen, which was the reading anyway and which everyone in the barn knew was also not the reading anyway.

He did not name anything. He talked about the servant who was forgiven ten thousand talents and went out and took his fellow servant by the throat for a hundred pence, and he said, once, in the middle of it, in a voice that did not change from the voice he had been preaching in:

"Forgiveness is not a lid you put on a thing. It is what you do after the thing is out in the open. If you put a lid on it and call that forgiveness, then in nine years' time you will find you have not forgiven anything at all — you have only made everybody carry it in silence, and called their silence peace."

Rebecca sat on the fourth bench with her mother on one side and Naomi Esh on the other, and did not cry, and understood that she had just heard a sixty-one-year-old man confess in front of his entire district in the only way a bishop can.

Afterward, at the meal, she got up to take a plate to old Naomi and found Daniel Beiler at her elbow.

"Walk out to the gate with me," he said, "and let them all see it, and get it over with."

"That's the worst idea you've ever had."

"It's the second worst." He held the door. "The worst was leaving."

And Rebecca Yoder walked out of the Fishers' barn in front of the whole district with Daniel Beiler beside her, in the light of the tenth of April, and the ground was soft, and there was green coming up in the ditches.

The Tenth Winter

The case took fourteen months, which everybody had told her and nobody had made her understand.

Wilmer Graber pleaded to the wage charges in the following March: two counts, restitution ordered, a fine, no custody. The assault went to a hearing and then, eleven days before trial, to a plea as well: a lesser count, two years' probation, his name on a list.

He sold the pit that summer to a company out of Harrisburg and moved to Ohio, where his daughter was.

The restitution was ordered in March and paid in the November after that, which Cruz said was fast. Two of the five men could be found. The other three had gone, and the money for them sat in an account in Harrisburg against the day somebody came for it, and as far as Rebecca ever knew nobody did.

Nobody was ever charged with anything to do with the sixteenth of January.

Detective Cruz drove out to Willow Creek herself to tell Rebecca that the 2017 file would not be reopened, and sat in the kitchen and said it plainly, and did not dress it up, and stayed forty minutes afterward drinking coffee and talking about nothing, which Rebecca understood to be the actual purpose of the visit.

"For what it's worth," Cruz said at the door, "I put it in the file that the investigating officer in 2017 failed to canvass seasonal labor. It's a paragraph. It'll be read by nobody."

"Then why write it?"

"Because in nine years' time," said Marla Cruz, "somebody may pull that file, and it'll be there."

Rosa Mendez Herrera came to Willow Creek exactly once, in the October after the plea, with her husband and two children in a hatchback, and they all stood awkwardly in the Yoders' yard for ten minutes while the children looked at the horses.

Miriam brought out the good chairs. Nobody sat in them.

At the end of it Rosa said, "I wanted to see where she lived," and Rebecca walked her up the lane and pointed out the house and the barn and the road to the market stand, and did not take her to the quarry, and Rosa did not ask.

At the car Rosa said: "Does it help? Any of it?"

Rebecca thought about it honestly, which was the only kind of answer that woman deserved.

"It doesn't bring anything back," she said. "It stopped a thing that was still going. That's different from helping, but it isn't nothing."

Rosa nodded slowly.

"That's about what I've got as well," she said.

Miriam Yoder began to say her daughter's name again, in the second year, and never explained it and was never asked.

It started small. *Sarah used to do it that way.* *That's Sarah's stitch, that.* Once, in the middle of a March morning, with no warning at all: *she'd have been twenty-seven in the spring.*

In April of that year, without discussion, they moved the other bed out.

They did it together, on an ordinary Tuesday, and carried it down the stairs and out to the buggy shed, and Miriam stood in the empty half of the room for a while afterward with her hands on her hips and said, "It wants painting."

They painted it that week.

Daniel Beiler was baptized in the autumn of the second year, in a service that took four hours, with fourteen other people, most of them nineteen years old.

He knelt on the floor of the Kauffmans' barn at thirty-three among a row of teenagers, and Amos Stoltzfus poured water on his head from a tin cup, and afterward the men shook his hand one at a time in the old way, all of them, including three who had not spoken to him for a year and a half.

He finished the corner cupboard in the July of the second year.

Rebecca came up the Beilers' lane on a Tuesday evening with a basket for his mother and found him standing in the woodshed doorway looking at it, and she stopped in the yard because there was something in the way he was standing that made her not want to interrupt it.

It was, she thought, an extremely good cupboard. Cherry, with a shaped apron and a bead run down the stiles, and doors that hung so true you could not see the gap. Two years of a man's hands with nothing else to hold.

"It's done," she said.

"It's done."

"Your mother still doesn't want it."

"She says it's too fine for that kitchen and she'll have to keep the kitchen better." Daniel scratched the back of his neck. "She's been saying it all week and looking pleased about it."

Rebecca set the basket down on the block.

"What'll you make now?"

And Daniel Beiler said, without turning round: "That's rather the question."

She waited.

"I've had two years of it," he said. "Fitting a thing I didn't need to fit, badly on purpose, so I'd have somewhere to be. And the whole time I've been telling myself: when it's done, I'll know what comes after. Well, it's done."

"And do you?"

He turned around then.

"I know what I'd like to come after," he said. "I've known since the fence, if I'm honest, and that was eighteen months ago, and I've said nothing because for most of that time you had a thing to carry and I'd not have had you carry me as well."

The evening was very still. Somewhere behind the house a screen door went.

"And now?" Rebecca said.

"Now the man's in Ohio and the case is finished and your mother says your sister's name at the table." Daniel's hands were at his sides and he did not seem to know what to do with them, which she found, in a man of thirty-three who could hang a door true, entirely disarming. "So now I'd like to ask you, and I'd like to do it badly, because I've had two years to think of a good way and everything I came up with sounded like something out of a book."

"Then ask it badly."

"Rebecca." He took a breath. "I've been in love with you since I was seventeen years old and too stupid to know what it was, and I went away for nine years and it didn't go anywhere, and I came back for forgiveness and got something I hadn't the right to hope for. I'd like to marry you. And if the answer's no I'll not ask again and I'll not make it hard for you, and I'll go on being here, because this is my district now and I'll not leave it a second time."

Rebecca Yoder stood in a yard in July with her hands in her apron.

She had known, of course. She had known since the winter, since a woodshed in February, since a man saying *I'd rather be it here for a year with a reason*, since the walk out of the Fishers' barn in front of the whole district on the tenth of April with everybody watching and Daniel Beiler holding the door and saying *let them all see it, and get it over with.*

What surprised her was not the question.

What surprised her was that there was nothing at all in the way. She had spent nine years with a thing standing between herself and every ordinary future, so solidly and for so long that she had stopped seeing it as a thing and had begun to think of it as the shape of the world. And it had gone. Not resolved, and it would never be resolved, but moved, set down, put where she could walk around it.

"You'll have to ask my mother," she said.

Daniel went white and then red.

"That's — is that — "

"That's yes, Daniel." She was smiling, which she had not planned to do. "But you'll ask her, and you'll do it properly, and I'll tell you now she'll say something that sounds like no for the first thirty seconds. That's just how she is. Wait it out."

Miriam Yoder said something that sounded like no for approximately forty seconds.

Then she went to the dresser, took out a tin, and put on the table a bank book with two thousand four hundred dollars in it that she had been putting away five and ten at a time for nine years without telling anybody, for a wedding she had assumed she would never be asked to pay for.

"I'd stopped expecting it," she said, to nobody in particular. "But I never stopped putting it in."

He married Rebecca Yoder the following November.

It was not a large wedding by the standards of the district. Three hundred and forty people, which was small, and everyone noticed it was small, and everyone also noticed who came.

Sadie Beiler came.

The four families who had left the meal early did not, and Rebecca had known they would not, and had sent them each an invitation anyway, in her own hand, because Naomi Esh had told her to. ("You'll not have them," Naomi had said, "but they'll have had the asking, and that's yours to give and theirs to refuse, and in fifteen years it'll matter which of you did which.")

Their first was a boy. Their second, two years after, was a girl.

They named her Sarah, which was not the custom (the Amish do not name a child for the dead in that way, not usually, not so soon) and there was some talk about it, and Amos Stoltzfus said nothing about it at all, publicly or privately, which was how Rebecca knew what he thought.

Of the four families who had left the meal early, three came back.

Not at once, and not with anything said. That was not how it was done. One Sunday in the second summer the Eshes were simply there again, in their old place, and Rebecca's mother passed them the bread at the meal and nobody remarked on it and it was over.

The fourth family moved to a district near Belleville in the autumn of that year, and gave as their reason the price of land, which was a real reason and also not the reason, and everybody understood both things and said nothing.

Rebecca thought about them more than she expected to.

She had been told she would be hated and had braced for it, and what had actually happened was smaller and more wearing: for about eighteen months there were perhaps nine people in Willow Creek who were slightly cooler with her than they had been, in ways too small to name and too consistent to imagine. A greeting that came half a beat late. Being asked second instead of first. Nothing you could take to anybody. Nothing you could even be sure of.

And then it had gone, the way weather goes, and she could not have said in which month.

The one who never came round was Sadie Beiler, who had washed the floors of the Yoder house on her knees for a week in the January that Sarah died. She came

to the wedding, and shook Rebecca's hand, and said the right things. And in the eleven years after it she never once sat at the same table.

Rebecca stopped minding it in the end, or nearly. She understood the arithmetic of it: Sadie had given the one thing she had to give, in the worst week of another woman's life, and had believed she was buying peace with it. To be told nine years later that the peace had been the wrong shape, that the floors had been washed over a hole, was not a thing you could simply be talked out of.

You take what people can give, Naomi Esh said once, on the subject, at ninety-one, with her mouth full. *And you don't send it back because it wasn't enough.*

Emma Stoltzfus sent for her in the March of the third year, at four in the morning, for her fourth.

Rebecca had wondered what she would do if that ever happened, and had settled on the answer that she would go, because there was no other answer a midwife had, and had also privately expected to be sent for somebody else.

The labour was quick and unremarkable and the child was a boy. Afterward, in the grey of it, with the room tidied and the water carried out, Emma held her son and said, without looking up:

"I've wanted to say something to you for two years and I've never once got it right in my head."

"Then don't," Rebecca said. "It's four in the morning and you've a son."

Emma Stoltzfus laughed, wetly, once.

They never did discuss it, that year or any year after. Emma sent for her for the fifth as well, and the sixth, and that was the whole of what was ever said about it, and both of them understood it perfectly.

She still counted.

That was the thing she had not expected, and that she never told anyone, not even Daniel: the counting did not stop. It had simply changed its shape.

For nine years it had been *two days*, *nine years and two days*, the arithmetic of a thing without a cause, done in the back of her mind while her hands worked.

Now it was other numbers. Nine hundred dollars a year off five men. Fifteen a week. Five months from the seventeenth of August to the sixteenth of January. Eleven pages. Fourteen months of a case. And, threaded through all of it, the

number she had never been able to get to and never would: whatever happened in twenty minutes on a night in January, on the north side of a flooded quarry, between a girl who had decided something and whatever came down that road with its lights off.

She would not have that. She had made her peace with not having it, which was not the same as peace and was as close as she was going to get.

On the sixteenth of January in the tenth year, Rebecca Beiler went out to the quarry.

She went alone, in the buggy, on a gray afternoon with the light going, and stood at the wire fence the county had put up in the spring after her sister drowned.

There was nothing to see. There had never been anything to see.

She had brought nothing to leave, because leaving things at the water would have been a foreign kind of gesture, the sort of thing *Englischers* did with flowers at roadsides, and Sarah would have thought it ridiculous.

So she stood at the fence with her hands in her sleeves and said, out loud, in the ordinary voice she used for the ordinary business of her days:

"They know now. All of it that could be known. Efrain's daughter said it in a room with a machine running and I was not there and it was not my doing, and the man is in Ohio, and there is a paragraph in a file that says the police did their work badly." She stopped. "And I could not get the rest. I want you to know I tried and could not get it."

The pines moved.

"I'm going to stop coming," Rebecca said.

She had not known she was going to say that, and having said it she understood that she had decided it some time ago: perhaps in a kitchen, perhaps in a shanty in a field, perhaps standing in a barn doorway watching a truck go down a lane.

"Not because it's finished," she said. "It isn't and it won't be. Because I've a girl at home with your name and I'll not raise her in January."

She stood a moment longer.

"*Denki*," she said. "For writing it down. Nobody asked you to and you did it for nine months and it was the only reason any of it ever came out at all."

Then Rebecca Beiler turned around and got up into the buggy and drove home in the last of the light, past the crossroads, past the Millers' lane and the phone shanty, past the fence along the Beiler south pasture that had never needed

mending, up her own lane to a house where the lamp was lit in the kitchen window and a man was walking a crying baby up and down in front of the stove.

Behind her, two miles back, the ice lay on the water the way it did every January, and would every January, and would still be lying there long after everyone who remembered had gone.

But the counting was done.

A Word Before You Go

Thank you for reading *The Ninth Winter*.

Books like this one live or die on word of mouth. If you have two minutes, an honest review on Amazon, of any length and any number of stars, helps another reader decide whether this is a story for them. That is the whole of it.

It matters more than it sounds like it should.

With thanks, Rebecca Miller

About the Author

Rebecca Miller writes quiet suspense set in Plain communities, where the hardest thing a person can do is say a name out loud. She lives in Pennsylvania. *THE NINTH WINTER* is her first novel.